

FROM THE STORM TO THE FIRE

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Front Matter

- Introduction
- Preface: The Wiring

Part I: The Foundations

- Chapter 1: The Storm Outside
- Chapter 2: The Fire Ignites

Part II: Entanglement and Escalation

- Chapter 3: Twenty Years of Static
- Chapter 4: The Collapse and the Breaking Point

Bridge: Turning on the Light

Part III: Adrift

- Chapter 5: Adrift in North Dakota

Part IV: Decoding the Fire

- Chapter 6: Shifting the Blame
- Chapter 7: The Glass Box Blueprint
- Chapter 8: Echoes and Amplifiers
- Chapter 9: Reflections from the Inside

- **Chapter 10: The Rescue Boat**
- **Chapter 11: The Second Wound**

Part V: Reckoning and Rising

- **Chapter 12: Conversations at Midnight**
 - **Chapter 13: Letters of Healing**
- **Chapter 14: The Ember Still Burns**

Part VI: Forging the Flame

- **Chapter 15: From the Wreckage to the Rising Flame**
 - **Chapter 16: My Body Kept the Score**
 - **Chapter 17: Finding the Map in the Madness**
- **Chapter 18: The Complex Dance of Connection**
 - **Chapter 19: The Ongoing Path**

Final Thought

Appendix: Research Notes, Legal Timeline, and Loss List

INTRODUCTION

This ain't a triumph story. There's no bow on top. And it ain't a pity party either. I'm not here to beg for your tears.

I'm here to tell you how a three-pound baby wired for danger in a glass box grew up to fight a war inside his own skin for forty-three years.

My name is Daniel. I'm from Clarksville, Arkansas. I live with C-PTSD. I live with addiction. I live with the ghosts of twenty-seven dead people I loved. And I'm still standing.

This book is the map. It's the wreckage. It's the truth about what happens when a nervous system gets carved by violence before it even knows what safety feels like.

It's about the meth pipe that promised peace and delivered hell.

It's about a twenty-year marriage that felt like a slaughterhouse.

It's about the kids I love more than breath—Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, Adalee—who deserved a father who wasn't drowning.

I wrote this because silence kills.

I wrote this because I needed to know why I kept burning down every bridge I crossed.

I wrote this so you know you ain't crazy if your brain feels like a fire alarm that won't shut off.

This is the storm outside.

This is the fire within.

And this is the ember that refused to die.

PREFACE: THE WIRING

For years, I thought I was broken. Lazy. Toxic. Crazy.

My ex-wife told me I was bipolar. Doctors slapped labels on me like tags on a carcass. I believed them. I took the pills. I drank the booze. I smoked the meth. I thought it was a character flaw.

Then a therapist looked me in the eye and said, "It's not what's wrong with you. It's what happened to you."

Complex PTSD. C-PTSD.

It clicked like a key in a rusted lock.

It ain't just one bad day.

It's a lifetime of them.

It starts in the NICU. Thirty days. No mother's touch. Just wires and alarms and a priest giving me last rites because I was dying.

My body learned distance before it learned love. It learned that survival means staying still. Staying quiet. Don't take up space.

Then came the violence.

Age six. Hiding under a blanket while my mom got beaten.

Learning that danger erupts without warning. Learning that freezing is the only way to survive.

Then came the losses.

My cousin Nicholas—ruled suicide, felt like murder.

My brother Garrett—dead at thirty-two in a wreck I couldn't stop.

My mom—gone in 2021.

Twenty-seven names on a list of dead people I loved.

When you live like that, your brain changes. It stops looking for peace and starts scanning for threats. It catastrophizes because tragedy is the only thing that feels real.

When I missed court dates, it wasn't defiance.

It was freeze.

My body locked up like it did under that blanket.

When I used drugs, it wasn't because I didn't love my kids. It was because the pain had no off switch and I needed to survive the night.

I'm not telling you this to excuse the damage. I caused pain. I failed my kids. I burned relationships. I own that.

But understanding the wiring stops the shame from eating me alive.

It shifts the question from "Why am I so fucked up?" to "How did I survive this long?"

PROLOGUE: THE PREDICTIVE MODEL

People call it paranoia. I call it data.

My brain predicts the worst because the worst is usually what happens.

The Start: Born dying in an incubator. Wiring set to danger.

The Systems: Cops ruled my cousin's death suicide when it was murder. So yeah, I don't trust the legal system.

The Loss: When you lose twenty-three people, expecting tragedy isn't negative. It's realistic.

The Cycle: Stress hits. Brain freezes. I miss court. Warrant issues. See? I told you it would go to hell.

It's a self-fulfilling prophecy built on evidence.

So when you read this, know this: I'm not looking for salvation. I'm looking for understanding.

I'm not asking you to fix me. I'm telling you how the machine works so you know why it broke.

This ain't therapy. This is testimony.

The storm hit hard. The fire burned hot. But the ember is still here.
Turn the page.

PART I: THE FOUNDATIONS

Chapter 1: The Storm Outside

They said I was born early, but I've always felt late.

Seven months in, and the world pulled me out before I was ready. Three pounds, four ounces of unfinished life dropped into a glass box of wires and alarms. I spent my first thirty days inside an incubator—no arms around me, no skin against skin, just machines and a kind of silence that never really leaves you.

My mom was there as much as they would let her be. She wasn't absent the way people sometimes assume in stories like mine. She came. She stayed. She loved me. She just wasn't allowed to hold me the way a mother is supposed to hold her baby. That matters. But so does this: my body still learned separation before it learned comfort.

A few days after I was born, my system started shutting down. They called a priest to my incubator. He gave me last rites while the monitors screamed around him. Then something shifted. My vitals came back. I stayed.

I didn't understand any of that, obviously. But my nervous system did.

It learned that survival was unstable.

My dad later told me those first weeks weren't total isolation. My mom came when she could. That matters too. But the wiring was already being written by then. Distance came first. Connection came second, if it came at all.

I even had a picture once—my brother reaching through the hand holes of the incubator, playing with me through plastic. I don't know where it went. I wish I still had it. I miss him. That image is what I think about when I try to understand how I started: somebody reaching for me through glass.

That's what the beginning felt like, even before I had language for it.

The storm outside didn't take long to find us.

After my parents split, everything changed. New houses. New routines. New versions of normal that never lasted long enough to become real. One of the men who entered our lives brought violence with him. Not loud all the time. Not obvious from the outside. But when it came, it came hard.

I was six.

I learned the sounds first.

A voice changing shape.

A door hit too hard.

A body moving across a room with the wrong kind of purpose.

Then came the crashes. The yelling. My mother's voice breaking in ways a kid should never hear.

I would pull a blanket over myself and hold still like stillness could make me disappear. The blanket smelled like mildew and old detergent. I twisted it in my fists until my hands hurt. My heart pounded so hard it felt like it might give me away.

Sometimes I stayed in bed.

Sometimes I hid in a cabinet.

Sometimes I crawled into a closet.

Whatever space looked smallest. Safest. Whatever space felt like it could erase me enough to get me through the night.

That was the rule my body learned early: if danger is bigger than you, become smaller.

I heard my mom scream. I heard things break. I heard the sounds of a grown man tearing through a room like he owned the fear in it. Some nights I heard her begging him to stop. Some nights I heard nothing at all after the noise, and that silence scared me worse.

Once, I peeked through a crack and saw her arm hanging wrong. Just wrong. Limp in a way I didn't have words for then. I knew it meant pain. I knew it meant I couldn't fix it.

CPS came to the school once and asked questions about bruises and getting hurt at home. Me and my sister answered like kids who didn't know there was another way to live.

"Only when we are bad."

That was the answer.

I thought that was how homes worked.

I thought that was what getting raised felt like.

Some nights we ran.

Mom would burst in fast, scared and serious, telling us to get up right then. We would go barefoot into the dark, gravel biting into our feet while the night air cut our lungs open. We would run to my uncle's house, a big two-story place that felt like a castle compared to wherever we were sleeping then.

But even while we were running, I would look back for her.

And sometimes she wasn't right behind us.

That panic settled deep.

Not just that danger could happen. That escape could fail.

That you could be told to run and still not get away clean.

The violence didn't last forever. The man died when I was still young. I remember hearing about it and waiting for relief to show up.

It didn't.

That taught me something too.

Danger doesn't always leave when the person does.

Sometimes it stays behind in the body.

The nights followed me even after the house got quiet. I wet the bed until I was eleven. That kind of shame gets into a kid early. You start feeling guilty for things your body is doing without your permission. I didn't understand trauma. I only understood embarrassment.

Around ten, sleep itself became another battleground.

I started waking up frozen. Eyes open. Body gone. I could see the room but couldn't move. Couldn't call out. Couldn't do anything except lie there and feel something heavy pressing the air flat. Sometimes it felt like a presence. Sometimes it just felt like terror with weight on it.

The first time it happened, I thought I was dying.

Then it kept happening.

Later, the paralysis turned into something else. People told me I screamed in my sleep. Bloody murder, they said. The kind of scream that made people think somebody was being killed. I usually remembered nothing. I would wake to shaken shoulders and faces already scared before I had even opened my eyes.

To them, it sounded like horror.

To me, it felt like waking up late to my own body.

I didn't have words for any of it.

All I knew was that night wasn't safe anymore. I could be lying still, doing nothing, and my body would still find a way to panic. Silence didn't protect me. Sleep didn't protect me. My own bed didn't protect me.

Even in the dark, something in me stayed braced.

That was the shape of my childhood.

Not one single event. Not one easy villain. Not one clean wound.

It was glass first.

Then fear.

Then the lesson that survival meant getting small, staying quiet, and waiting for the danger to pass.

The problem is, for some bodies, it never really passes.

Mine just learned how to carry it.

INTERLUDE: THE BODY REMEMBERS

Sleep paralysis is when your brain wakes up before your body does. During REM sleep, your muscles shut down so you don't act out your dreams. Sometimes that shutdown lingers even after your mind clicks on. You open your eyes but can't move, can't speak, and often feel a crushing presence on your chest.

For people with complex trauma, this hits harder. Childhood trauma wires the nervous system for hypervigilance. The threat detector stays set to sensitive, always ready to blare. Sleep gets broken, REM cycles fragment, and the body never fully relaxes. When normal REM paralysis collides with a trauma-conditioned brain that refuses to go off duty, the result is conscious awareness inside a paralyzed body.

It's terrifying, but not random. It's the nervous system doing what it was trained to do: stay alive at all costs, even in sleep.

The paralysis that began at ten was only the beginning. As I grew older, paralysis gave way to something worse: the screams. Not conscious cries, but sounds ripped from somewhere deeper, primal alarms tearing through the night. I'd wake to shaken shoulders, to voices telling me I had been screaming bloody murder, but I remembered nothing.

It was trauma meeting physiology. Each time my airway collapsed, each time my brain starved for air, my nervous system went straight from freeze into flight, exploding out as screams I never chose. The child who had learned silence as survival was now crying out in the dark. The boy given last rites in an incubator was decades later still fighting for breath.

Those screams were distress calls from every version of me. My conscious mind slept, but my body remembered everything. It remembered survival. It remembered danger. And it still fought to survive, long after the threats were gone.

CHAPTER 2: THE FIRE IGNITES

The storm died down by my teens, but a raw heat flickered alive—jumpy, sharp, mine. School was a pressure cooker—halls thick with shouts, lockers clanging, a hum that crushed my head. My hands trembled, not from drink but from people—too loud, too near. Social anxiety, I'd name it later; then, it was just "Why can't I shake this?" growled low, a buzzing under the surface ready to explode. Palms wet, shirt clinging, I'd dodge their eyes, convinced every glance held judgment.

Booze crept in early—sips from Uncle's cans at four, a kid playing big. At 16, it roared. A cousin's trailer, football blasting, table sticky with spills. He tossed me a Bud Light, said, "Go for it." I didn't stop—beer, Zimas, a tequila shot that scorched. Two hours, all gone. "I drank it," I mumbled, room tilting. He jolted up, "Bullshit." Nope. Woke on the bathroom floor—tile icy, head by the toilet, puke sour in my throat. "God, kill this, I'll quit," I croaked. Lie. It lit the fire—booze dulled the shakes, made me loose. I chased it hard, desperate for the quiet it offered inside my head, the brief escape from the constant tension.

By 17, it ruled. Wild Turkey and vodka, one in each hand—shots swapping, throat raw. Then blood came up—red in the sink, ulcers clawing my gut. My own body felt like it was attacking me from the inside. Switched to beer—lighter, less pain. Headaches pulsed, a stab behind my eyes; the world swayed if I moved quick. I'd slump, can sweating in my grip, knowing it was wrecking me. Couldn't stop. The need to numb was stronger than the pain.

The storm eased up when I was thirteen. My parents remarried—Mom and Dad patched things up, and for a minute, it felt like peace. Like we'd rebuilt the wall after years of shelling. For once, home didn't feel like a battlefield.

But by fifteen, I was burning inside. Quiet fire, twitchy and hot. School became a cage—crowded halls, loud voices, too many eyes. I shook like I was trying to hold back an earthquake. So I walked. Grabbed a GED and told everyone it was for money, for work.

Half-truth. The whole truth? I just couldn't breathe in there anymore.

I moved in with my uncle—a big man, Vietnam vet, Purple Heart on the wall, cold beer always in reach. The music was good. The stories were better. I drank for free, sixteen to seventeen, lost in a haze that felt like home.

Then everything broke.

His son—my cousin, my blood—took a bullet to the head. Cops called it suicide. I didn't buy it. No way. He smiled too much, loved too hard. But this was Johnson County, Arkansas. Three deaths in three months, all linked to the same girl, and nobody batted an eye. Just another chapter in a town that eats its own.

After he died, I unraveled. Suicidal thoughts hit like a freight train in '99. I spent a month in the hospital. Quit weed. Got sober. Swore I'd become a cop—get justice, dig out the truth. I interviewed at the jail, spent a few hours shadowing the day shift. At the end, the guy looked me in the eye and said, "You just want to learn the system so you can help your people when they get locked up." Wrote me off like I was already dirty.

That's when I learned what small-town judgment really costs.

Fifteen years later, I did the digging myself. We were right. It was murder. But it wasn't Teddy—it was Johnny. Pulled the trigger while Kris, my cousin's girlfriend, stood by. She went to the store before it happened, came back all tears and gasps, like she didn't know. It was staged. All of it. My uncle shattered. Tried to take his life twice while I was just down the hall. First time it was pills scattered like confetti across the kitchen table. Second time, he put a .22 in his gut. I called my mom, barely able to speak. "I'm not right," I choked out. First real panic attack—sweat, gasping, no air. Childhood fear, grown teeth, and came back to chew.

At seventeen, pain found a new way in.

A migraine knocked me flat. Blinding. Nauseating. I was sprawled on the couch in the dark, whispering, "Turn the lights off." Mom handed me a pill—hydro, something numbing. Thirty minutes later, I was at the sink, scrubbing dishes like I was reborn.

"What is this?" I asked, soap dripping from my hands.

"Kills pain. Feels good," she said.

I'd never touched a damn plate before—but now I was floating. The next day, I popped one before work at Western Sizzlin. Thought, This'll make the grind bearable.

By seventeen, I was hooked. Hydros, Tylenol 3s and 4s, Darvocets, morphine, K-pins, chewed-up fentanyl patches. Anything that numbed. Later, Roxy, straight to the vein. I wasn't just silencing physical pain—I was muting the constant roar inside. That fire? It didn't just burn—it consumed.

CHAPTER 3: PAIN TAKES ROOT

The discharge papers from '99 said I was stable. I told myself I was done. Clean slate. Straight line. I actually believed it for about three weeks.

You don't walk out of a psych ward healed. You walk out raw. The alarms hadn't reset. The wiring hadn't changed. The only difference was I was supposed to carry it without the chemical buffer. Then the migraine came back. Blinding. The kind that makes you bargain with the ceiling. I knew where the pills were. I told myself it was just this once. Just to function.

"Just this once" is how dependency takes root. Not with a party. Not with rebellion. With a Tuesday. A ten-hour shift on the line, grease on my hands, sweat in my eyes, and a hydrocodone in my palm that turned the volume down from screaming to hum. I didn't feel high. I felt normal. That's the trap. Normal is the most addictive state you'll ever chase when your baseline is panic.

By nineteen, I wasn't using to escape. I was using to operate. Tylenol 3s, Darvocets, whatever I could source. I learned the math of maintenance: how many milligrams get you through a double, how to split a pill to stretch it, how to keep your voice steady when your pupils pin and your hands shake. I wasn't living. I was running a machine on borrowed fuel.

The outside looked like a man holding it together. I showed up. I worked. I nodded through conversations. But every interaction was filtered through chemical equilibrium. I'd smile while my nervous system ran on fumes. I'd make plans while my brain calculated the next dose. Pain wasn't a warning anymore. It was the baseline. And the pills weren't recreation—they were infrastructure.

I got good at it. Too good. The better I performed, the deeper the dependency sank. I told myself I was in control. I wasn't. I was just pacing myself inside a cage I'd built bolt by bolt. Every relapse wasn't a moral failure. It was a nervous system demanding equilibrium it couldn't generate on its own. I didn't know the language then. I just knew the silence the pills bought, and how expensive it got over time.

The town felt smaller. The options felt thinner. I wasn't looking for love. I was looking for an anchor. Someone to tether me to the surface when the internal current tried to drag me under. I didn't know it then, but I was already building the structure. I just hadn't met the lock yet.

Then came the steakhouse. The dish pit. The bet. I thought I was playing a game. I didn't know I was signing a twenty-year lease on my own nervous system. I thought I was choosing a girl. I was just choosing the next place to hide.

Pain doesn't announce itself as a life sentence. It moves in quietly. Takes up a chair. Learns your routines. By the time you realize it's never leaving, you're already paying rent. And I was already packed.

CHAPTER 4

TWENTY YEARS OF STATIC

"Understand: people will constantly attack you in life. One of their main weapons will be to instill in you doubts about yourself—your worth, your abilities, your potential."

— Robert Greene

At seventeen, a stupid bet changed everything.

My cousin and I were pushing each other hard at the steakhouse—racing in the dish pit, competing on the line, counting send-backs like battle scars. One Sunday, he swaggered in talking about some girl he'd spent the weekend with. Teenage arrogance kicked in.

“I'll have her attention by Wednesday,” I shot back.

Twenty years, four kids, and a obliterated marriage later, it turns out I won that bet.

I wish I'd lost it.

At first, I tried to dismiss Trinity. She was a challenge, something to prove. But she had a relentless persistence that cut through my bullshit. I'd say I was working, then drive ten miles out of town to shoot hoops at some random park. She'd show up anyway. Parties, friends' houses—someone would always come get me. She was outside. Drunk. Determined.

Three months in, she dropped the bomb: pregnant.

My gut knew this wasn't love. But it was responsibility. My kid deserved better than what I'd grown up with. So I went into overdrive—two jobs, grinding until I had us a paid-off trailer and a car with no payments.

On August 10, 2002, our first child, Maverick, was born. We were still in Clarksville, trying to build a family on top of a fault line.

Not even a year later, on June 7, 2003, our second child, Shayla, came into the world.

Only after Shayla was born did we move to Little Rock, where I juggled college and full-time work, trying to build something solid on unstable ground with two kids already here and a nervous system I didn't understand.

The next twenty years ran on a permanent loop.

Break up. Crash back together. Love twisted with wreckage. Over and over. Even when we were apart, it never stopped burning.

Trinity learned where my soft spots were. The kids became weapons. Step out of line, and she'd threaten to kick me out. The thought of losing them was pure terror—another abandonment my nervous system couldn't survive. I tried to leave. Tried to set boundaries. I always came back. For them. Never for her.

The cycle never broke.

One day, my oldest daughter—maybe sixteen—looked me dead in the eye and asked,

“Why do you let Mom be so mean to you? Why don't you find someone nicer?”

That shattered me. I thought I'd hidden the damage. Turns out kids see everything.

I already had demons, but this relationship made me small. Any time I hurt—grief, stress, the weight of existing—it got turned back on me.

“You think you're suffering? Try being me.”

“Be a man.”

“Most people grow up.”

“It’s all in your head.”

“You’re obsessing and making something that’s not there.”

There was no comfort. No curiosity. Just my pain reframed as selfishness.

Any time in that twenty-year marriage that I tried to explain what I was feeling, she’d start talking about how she had it worse. I’d open my mouth to say, “I’m not okay,” and end up listening to a monologue about her stress, her struggles, her life. My feelings never got answered. They got erased.

Then came the verdict:

I was selfish.

I “only thought about” myself.

You hear that long enough, it sinks into your bones.

At the time, I didn’t know a damn thing about Complex PTSD. I didn’t know what a nervous system was, or what hypervigilance meant. All I knew was that being around people felt like too much and my body was constantly on edge, so I called it social anxiety, because that was the only label I had. I thought I was just weak. Broken. Needy. I thought the problem was me.

When I relapsed, she didn’t help. She punished. Kicked me out. Weaponized the kids. I learned fast: don’t bring pain here. That kind of rejection doesn’t just hurt—it rewires you. Maybe that’s why I drank the way I did. Or maybe that was just the lie I told myself to keep from screaming.

Looking back now, with therapy and brutal self-examination behind me, I can see what I couldn’t then. At the time, I only saw her control, her cruelty, my weakness for staying. I didn’t know my nervous

system had been wired for constant alarm since infancy—through NICU trauma, childhood chaos, and a lifetime of hypervigilance. I was living with undiagnosed C-PTSD and no language for why everything felt like a threat.

In 2020, Trinity was working as a nurse, so I went to her doctor, a woman she trusted. Trinity told her I was bipolar. I didn't correct it.

At the time, I was hiding a meth addiction. I assumed the chaos in my head was chemical—self-inflicted. Mood swings. Agitation. Crashes. I thought it was the drugs.

So I stayed quiet.

The diagnosis stuck. Bipolar. Depression. Medications stacked up—blood pressure, cholesterol, vitamin D, testosterone shots, B12, metformin. I became a walking pharmacy, treating symptoms while the real wound kept bleeding.

For years, I believed the story we were all telling: my addiction was the problem. A character flaw. Something broken in me. I didn't know then that substances weren't the disease—they were my desperate attempt to regulate a nervous system stuck in constant alarm.

And when the labels from outside weren't enough, I went hunting for worse ones myself.

I started reading about Borderline Personality Disorder. On paper, it fit too well: emotional chaos, relationship wreckage, shame, fear of abandonment, the way every conflict felt like the end of the world. I didn't have anyone giving me a better map, so I grabbed that one. I self-diagnosed as borderline and carried that like a guilty verdict for over a year.

I wasn't saying "poor me."

I was saying, “If this is what I am, at least now I know why I ruin everything.”

Meanwhile, agoraphobia was closing in like a vise. Walking outside felt like stepping into incoming fire. Going to the mailbox might as well have been walking into a riot. My chest would tighten at the thought of leaving the house. My whole system went on red alert just stepping toward the door.

That’s when I finally reached out and got a therapist on the line.

Two minutes into our first conversation, she cut through years of noise.

“You don’t have BPD,” she said. “You have Complex PTSD. And you’ve been manipulated.”

Just like that.

One sentence, and the floor shifted.

She explained that C-PTSD gets mistaken for BPD all the time. From the outside, trauma-wired behavior looks like instability, like “personality problems.” People see the outbursts, the shutdowns, the panic, the relationship chaos. They don’t see the blueprint underneath—the NICU, the violence, the losses, the twenty years of static.

Under all that mess, she said, I didn’t have a broken personality. I had a trauma injury.

That word—manipulated—hit harder than the diagnosis.

Because suddenly, my whole marriage snapped into focus:

The one-upping every time I tried to talk about my pain.
The “you’re selfish, you only think about yourself.”
The “be a man, most people grow up.”
The “it’s all in your head, you’re making something that’s not there.”
The way I ended up believing I was the monster in every room.

I had spent years calling myself every ugly name I could find when the truth was simpler and sharper: I’d been hurt, invalidated, and gaslit until I turned the knife on myself.

Eventually, even Trinity’s family turned on the chaos. After one separation, they gave her an ultimatum:

“Take him back, or we’re done helping you.”

She took me back—but in secret.

For a year, I stayed silent when her family called. When they visited, I hid in closets—literally becoming invisible, just like I’d learned as a kid. She kept me blocked on Facebook, status set to single, refusing to acknowledge our marriage publicly.

We were legally married with four kids.

And I was hiding in closets.

Her refrain—“I’m tired of raising you like a child”—drove the shame deeper. My fawn response, perfected early, convinced me that erasing myself was the only way to keep any kind of peace. I distrusted my own perceptions, which made her gaslighting—intentional or not—devastatingly effective.

Those moments in closets weren’t a metaphor some therapist cooked up. They were literal. Proof that my existence felt like something that needed to be hidden.

In 2015, it all collapsed. Trinity and my mother tag-teamed me into court-ordered rehab for twenty-one days. The stated reason was concern. The real reason was control—I was trying to leave town with another woman they didn't approve of.

The counselor saw it immediately.

“You'll relapse,” he said. “You're not here by choice. Pain with desperate coping mechanisms attached. I see it all the time.”

He wasn't wrong.

I kicked daily opiates. Spent six months on Suboxone. Quit that too. The pain stayed, so I switched weapons. From 2015 to 2021, meth became my escape—sometimes injected, sometimes traded for alcohol depending on which demon showed up first.

People like to say I “chose drugs over my family.”

From the outside, it's a clean story.

From the inside, it's a lie.

I didn't stand there calmly choosing between a meth pipe and my kids like two items on a menu. I chose, over and over, not to implode under a level of pain and shame that never shut off. I chose the only thing I'd found that could slam the volume down in my head long enough to make it through another night.

It hurt them. It hurt me. It wrecked trust and burned bridges I may never fully rebuild. I own that.

But underneath, the engine wasn't lack of love. It was a nervous system stuck in survival mode, grabbing whatever would stop the screaming inside my own skull for a few hours. It was a body that had

learned, from incubators and beatings and funerals and twenty years of static, that nobody was coming.

I didn't choose drugs over my family.
I chose not to die, with the only shitty tools I had.

I wasn't healing.

I was surviving.

Chapter 4 Reflection — The Static Beneath the Storm

For twenty years, I thought I was fighting a relationship.

I wasn't.

I was fighting a nervous system locked in survival mode. The freezing, dissociation, and desperate need to disappear weren't character flaws or side effects of "being an addict." They were trauma responses—echoes of a six-year-old under a blanket, of a grown man hiding in closets in his own house.

I didn't know why my body shut down under pressure. I didn't know why conflict felt lethal. I didn't know why walking into a store could feel like walking into a firing line. I thought I was lazy, selfish, weak, maybe borderline, maybe bipolar—whatever label hurt the most.

Therapy finally gave me the language to understand what had always been there:

an invisible blueprint of trauma shaping every reaction.

Complex PTSD.

Manipulation.

A brain and body that had been on "danger" since birth.

Understanding this hasn't erased the damage or the years lost.

But it gave me something I never had before:

The knowledge that the static in my head wasn't proof of brokenness.

It was proof of survival.

CHAPTER 5: THE COLLAPSE

By 2020, the fire had eaten everything.

Trinity took the kids—Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, Adalee—and left the four-bedroom house hollow. I couldn't afford it alone. Didn't need the space anyway. I moved in with a buddy, mattress on his floor, my life compressed down to whatever fit beside it. The meth pipe stayed within reach. My skin crawled. My teeth chattered. Smoke kept me upright—barely.

What started around September 2020 hardened into a pattern: daily use, broken only by short, fragile attempts at sobriety that never lasted more than a couple of weeks. I hadn't taken psychiatric medication since before COVID. I quit all of it abruptly, around the same time everything else fell apart. I told myself I was managing.

In December 2021, reality punched through whatever illusion I had left.

Mom was in the living room. I was in my old bedroom with friends—laughter sharp, meth humming through the walls. "Guys, I don't feel right," she called out. Quiet at first. Then louder. "I'm dizzy. I'm gonna fall."

Falon moved fast. Door flying open. Shouting for help. And I froze.

Not metaphorically. Not emotionally. Physically.

Exactly like I had under that blanket as a kid. My body locked while my mind went blank. People yelling my name. "Kali, move." I couldn't. Mom was on the floor. Falon grabbed her. Tina called 911. The living room filled with paramedics.

"Who am I?" my sister asked.

"Paula," Mom said—naming her dead sister.

Her blood sugar was over 600. "She won't make it," someone said. Three days later, her heart stopped in her sleep.

At the visitation, Walter drove. Truck door opened. The crowd closed in. I choked—sobs stuck somewhere behind my ribs. On the day of the funeral, I stayed in her house alone, her perfume still clinging to a scarf. Walter called. "Where are you?"

"Not going," I said.

His sister dragged me anyway. We got to the graveside mid-service. Thirty yards from the casket, I stopped. Dirt still raw. Voices low. They told me to sit up front. "No."

My boots stayed planted. Meth buzzing. Too far gone to feel it right. My brother was dead at thirty-two. Now my mom. Loss stacked on loss until I couldn't tell where grief ended and numbness began.

I'd tried rehab before. In 2019, I walked out after two weeks. My first call was from Trinity—bills, kids, stress. I thought leaving was what she wanted. Later she said it wasn't. In 2024, I checked myself in again. Three days later, I was medically discharged. Sleep apnea. No CPAP. Another failed attempt.

By then, I wasn't fighting to get better. I was fighting to stay conscious. The collapse wasn't dramatic. It wasn't loud. It was quiet, structural, and complete. Everything that had been holding me upright was gone.

Just a small decision. A non-event. One of those choices you make without understanding that your whole life may circle back to it later.

I would replay that decision for the rest of my life.

Halfway up the highway, my phone rang. It was Garrett. His voice was pure rage.

“What the fuck, dude? Greg's a cop. I would've ridden with him. You knew I wanted to go!”

Before I could answer, the line went dead.

THE WRECK

Later, the pieces came together.

After we left, Garrett took my dad's Xterra and drove to his girlfriend's place looking for his meds. She said she did not have them. He called the cops. Everything escalated. Then she called them back and accused him of rape. They questioned him for hours. Then they let him go.

By then, he was unraveling.

That night, he bought beer.

He drank.

Then he drove.

On Brick Plant Road, he lost control. Ninety miles an hour into a tree. The impact was so violent it threw the headlights fifty yards from the wreck.

Garrett died instantly.

THE PHONE CALL IN GOSHEN

Saturday morning in Kansas City felt normal until it didn't.

I was sitting in the U-Haul when Greg came out and told me I had a phone call. I followed him into the house. Someone handed me the phone.

It was Trinity.

"Garrett's gone," she said. "He's dead. There was a wreck."

The world stopped.

I don't remember whether I dropped the phone or handed it back. That part is gone.

I remember going outside.

I walked about thirty yards into the yard.

Then I collapsed.

I punched the ground because I needed something solid to hit. I looked up at the sky and screamed, “Fuck you, God. Fuck you.”

BETH’S MOM

Beth’s mom must have seen me in the yard. Maybe she heard me cussing God. She was the first person I remember seeing after the call.

I don’t remember having thoughts. It felt like I had just been born into pain. Like my mind had been wiped clean, and all that was left was this one impossible thing.

My brother was dead.

She opened her arms.

And I lost it.

She walked me over to the porch swing and sat down with me. I folded toward her like a little kid. My head ended up in her lap, and I

**cried like a two-year-old baby. Loud. Messy.
Snot and tears everywhere. All over her.**

**She did not pull away. She did not tell me to
calm down. She did not make a speech. She
did not try to fix it.**

She just sat there and rocked me.

I did not have words for it then.

Now I do.

**She lent me her nervous system until mine
could breathe again.**

**It may have been the kindest thing anyone
had ever done for me.**

**It was also the first time my emotions
outweighed my social anxiety. For once, I
was not worried about being seen.**

I was too broken to hide.

THE VERDICT

The guilt came right away.

Not as a question.

As a verdict.

If I would have woken him up.

If I had knocked on his door.

If I had not left without him.

He would have had different choices in front of him.

Maybe he would have gone to Kansas City.

Maybe he would have ridden with us.

Maybe he would not have gone to that house looking for his meds.

Maybe he would not have been questioned for hours.

Maybe he would not have bought the beer.

Maybe he would not have been on Brick Plant Road that night.

None of it felt like clean grief.

It felt like proof.

Proof that I was dangerous to the people I loved.

Proof that being close to me could get people hurt.

Proof that I had failed him.

STAYING AWAY FROM REAL

My cousin told me he would take me home right then.

I said no.

At the time, I probably told him I wanted to finish helping with the move. That was partly true. But the deeper truth was that I did not want to go home.

Some part of me believed that if I stayed in Kansas City, maybe it had not fully happened yet. Maybe it would not be real until I crossed back into Arkansas.

That night, we went to the Royals and Cubs game. It was my first professional baseball game. The stadium was packed. People were laughing, eating, cheering, and living inside a normal summer night. Hot dogs. Noise. Lights. Movement.

Everything around me was alive.

And I kept thinking, How is this still happening? How are people laughing? How are people eating hot dogs? How is there a baseball game right now?

My brother is dead.

But even that thought would not stay clear for long. It would rise up, and my body would push it back down.

Not yet.

Not here.

Not in front of all these people.

Not while I am this far from home.

I did not know the players.

I barely knew where I was.

I was there, but I was not there. Part of me was sitting in that stadium. Part of me was still holding the phone. Part of me was thirty yards out in that yard. Part of me was already back in Arkansas, standing beside whatever came next.

But my eyes kept going back to the field.

The grass.

It was not just green. It was vivid. Almost glowing. Like someone had turned the color all the way up.

I could not understand death.

I could not understand God.

I could not understand why Garrett was gone.

**But I could understand that grass. It was
right there. Bright. Still. Perfect. Alive.**

**My body could not hold the death yet, so it
held the field.**

**I think that is why I remember the grass
more than the game. Not the score. Not the
players. Not the inning.**

The grass.

**Because the grass did not ask me to explain
anything.**

**It just gave my eyes somewhere safe to
land.**

So I stayed in that place as long as I could.

Kansas City was distance.

**And distance was the only thing keeping the
truth from crushing me.**

ARKANSAS WAS REAL

**I think we drove the U-Haul back to
Arkansas on Sunday or Monday. That part is
blurry. Shock keeps some details sharp and
lets others fall away.**

What I remember clearly is the sign.

Welcome to Arkansas.

Now Entering Arkansas.

**Whatever it said, my body knew what it
meant.**

Kansas City was distance.

Arkansas was real.

My chest started to tighten.

I held it together in the truck.

I held it together when we got home.

**I held it together until I was lying in bed
beside Trinity.**

Then I felt it coming.

**I tried to hold it down. The harder it came,
the harder I fought it. Then my body started
shaking because there was too much
pressure inside me.**

The dam broke.

I started crying.

Then I heard her say:

“Shut up. I have to work tomorrow.”

**That sentence did not kill my marriage by
itself.**

But it showed me the truth.

Garrett was already gone.

**And something in my marriage died when I
was told to be quiet while I was breaking.**

The final split took another ten years.

But I knew that night.

I knew I was in the worst pain of my life.

And I was still alone.

CHAPTER 7: ADRIFT IN NORTH DAKOTA

After Garrett died, the unraveling didn't happen fast. It stretched. Frayed. Like a rope taking weight it was never meant to carry.

By the time my marriage finally collapsed in 2020, the fire had already been burning for years. The opiate addiction that started when I was seventeen had changed shape around 2015. Pills gave way to Suboxone for six months—just long enough to convince me I was stabilizing—before meth took over. Sometimes injected. Sometimes traded for alcohol. One master replacing another. The illusion of choice masking the same captivity.

When Trinity took the kids, the house emptied out in a way that felt physical. Four bedrooms reduced to echoes. I couldn't afford it alone. Didn't need the space anyway. I slept on a buddy's floor for a while, my life compressed down to whatever could fit beside a mattress and a pipe. I needed distance. A reset. Somewhere far enough away that the noise might finally stop. So I went north.

Williston, North Dakota. Full-time work at Love's Truck Stop. Cold air. Long hours. Structure. I told myself it was a fresh start. What I didn't understand yet was that you can't outrun a nervous system. You just give it new terrain.

The fire came with me.

Work became the next addiction. It was cleaner. Legal. Praised. I threw myself into it with the same compulsive intensity I'd always used to survive. If I stayed busy—stocking, cleaning, hauling, closing—maybe I wouldn't feel the weight of my mother's death in December 2021. Maybe I wouldn't think about the divorce. Maybe I wouldn't feel the ache of my kids being gone. For the first six months, they thought I was a miracle.

I worked like five people. Learned every position. Took every extra task. Unloaded trucks—dry goods, walk-in, deep freeze. Stocked everything. Cleaned what no one else wanted to touch. I trained new hires not because I was promoted, but because I'd absorbed everything through sheer, compulsive effort.

The praise came fast. The raises followed. For a while, it felt like proof that this time was different.

It never is.

Burnout doesn't announce itself. It creeps in quietly. One morning, I was scheduled for a 5 a.m. shift. I woke to pounding on my apartment window. Sunlight everywhere. It was 9 a.m. Shame hit like a gut punch. I swore it wouldn't happen again.

The next morning, it did.

Same pounding. Same time. Same humiliation.

A week later, I realized my alarm volume had somehow been set to mute. A simple explanation. Too late to matter. I was taken off mornings permanently and put on straight second shifts. That created its own hell.

We were perpetually short-staffed. For four solid months, I closed both restaurants alone. Every dish from two kitchens. Sweeping and mopping massive floors. Hauling trash. Cleaning three deep fryers. Boxing leftover food. Doing prep for the next day. Sometimes it was two in the morning before I left, reeking of grease and exhaustion.

Even then, boundaries didn't exist. The night manager from the store side—someone I didn't even technically work for—would wander back, see me drowning, and ask me to do extra tasks for him. Coffee. Cleaning. Whatever he didn't want to deal with.

I couldn't say no.

The best I could manage was to forget.

Social anxiety wrapped tighter the longer I stayed. Walking out of my apartment felt like stepping onto a stage. Every glance felt like judgment. I walked the entire perimeter of the building just to enter through the back, avoiding the front entrance. I took tasks in the back whenever I could.

Customer interaction drained me. Fluorescent lights buzzed like they were inside my skull.

I was constantly late—ten minutes, fifteen, sometimes thirty. Not because I didn't care, but because there was a war in my chest before every shift. The only jobs where it never happened were the ones where I was in charge.

When I wasn't working, I disappeared. I avoided stores unless it was an emergency. If Love's didn't stock what I needed, I paid someone else to go to Walmart. When I did go myself, it was at two or three in the morning. Less people. Less threat.

The move north didn't extinguish the fire.

It isolated it.

I was surrounded by people and completely alone. Sixteen-hour days and solitary closing shifts didn't silence grief or heal loss. They just proved what I'd been running from my whole life.

The storm wasn't outside.

It was me.

CHAPTER 8: BURNING IN COLD PLACES

After the fire, I didn't cool down.

I just burned differently.

I traded whiskey for work. Chaos for control. One addiction for another. From the outside, it looked like progress. Hell, even I thought it was progress.

I got clean.

I didn't get free.

What people called "getting my life together" was really obsession dressed up as discipline.

Speed. Precision. Performance. I worked like six people crammed into one exhausted body. Not healing—hiding.

I couldn't say no. I didn't ask for help. I took everything until I broke.

Lateness wasn't laziness. It was dread. The paralysis before the door. The moment where my body refused to move even when my mind begged it to. Depression doesn't punch a clock.

My brain was a fire alarm that never shut off. Every sound felt invasive. Every light too bright. Every voice a threat. I didn't know what "regulated" felt like. I didn't know you were supposed to feel safe inside your own skin.

The pattern never changed:

Get the job.

Overperform.

Get praised.

Get overwhelmed.

Crack.

Get punished.

Disappear.

Repeat.

When I wasn't working, I hid. Days blurred together. My phone stayed dark. Even grocery stores felt like arenas. I pushed a cart even when I didn't need one—just to have something to hold, something to justify my existence in that space.

I smiled. I joked. I performed.

That's how addicts survive.

People love the performance—

until you miss a cue.

I was still on fire.

Just in colder waters.

BRIDGE: TURNING ON THE LIGHT

You've walked through the wreckage with me. The blanket at six. The pipe at seventeen. The closets. The graveside where my boots wouldn't move. North Dakota at 2 a.m., pushing a cart just to feel real. It's heavy. I know.

I wrote it that way because you don't heal trauma by skipping the fire. You heal it by walking through it. But you can't put out a fire you don't understand. And for years, I didn't. I just kept grabbing whatever would stop the burning. Pills. Booze. Meth. Work. Hiding. All of it just different ways to slam the volume down on a nervous system that never got the all-clear.

Now I need to stop telling the story and start mapping it. Not because I want to sound smart. Not because I'm trying to distance myself from the pain. Because if I don't name the wiring, I'll keep tripping over it. You can't fix a machine you refuse to open. And this machine—the one wired in a glass box, calibrated by violence, reinforced by twenty years of static—has been running on broken logic since before I had words for it.

The next chapters aren't therapy. They're autopsy reports on my own survival. I'm going to show you how the NICU became a blueprint. How that blueprint met every storm that hit. How amplification turned sparks into infernos. How the body kept score when the mind was too busy trying to stay alive to notice.

I'm not leaving the story behind. I'm just turning on the light. So we can see what we're actually fighting.

Turn the page. Let's look at the wiring.

CHAPTER 8: ANATOMY OF A SPIRAL

Trinity, Tina, Kristina — Dissecting the Damage

This wasn't three love stories.

It was one wound wearing three different faces.

For years, I kept those names in separate boxes so I wouldn't have to look at the pattern straight on. Trinity was the marriage. Tina was the escape. Kristina was the mind game. Three different women. Three different disasters. Three different explanations for why everything in my life kept catching fire.

That version was easier to live with because it let me keep pretending each wreck was self-contained. If every collapse belonged to a different room, then maybe there was no architecture connecting them. Maybe I was just unlucky. Maybe I just picked the wrong people. Maybe the whole thing was random.

It wasn't random.

The women were different. The dynamics were different. The damage took different shapes. But the wound underneath was the same. Every one of those relationships plugged into the same circuitry: abandonment, shame, panic, self-erasure, and the deep animal terror that connection could disappear at any second.

That is the harder truth.

I did not move from one relationship to the next because I was learning. I moved because I was repeating. I was carrying the same raw wiring into different rooms and calling each fire by a different name. One relationship trained me to disappear. One made desperation feel like salvation. One held up a mirror and let my own unhealed mind finish the job.

This chapter is not a blame list. It is not a courtroom. It is not a plea for sympathy.

It is an autopsy.

Trinity

Trinity was not the beginning of my damage, but she became the longest environment my damage ever lived in.

When I met her, I was still young enough to confuse responsibility with readiness. A pregnancy came fast, and the part of me that had grown up around chaos latched onto the idea that I could outrun my own instability by building something solid on the outside. Work hard. Pay bills. Get

the trailer. Get the car. Show up. Be a dad. Be useful. Be necessary. If the frame looked stable enough, maybe nobody would notice the fire inside it.

From the outside, it probably looked like a life. Marriage. Kids. Jobs. A house. Schedules. Obligations. The ordinary pieces people point to when they say a man is doing what he is supposed to do.

Inside it, the static never stopped.

The pattern was always the same. Break up. Crash back together. Tension. Reconciliation. Withdrawal. Blowup. Silence. Repeat. It was not peace. It was proximity without safety.

For a long time, I thought the main damage in that marriage came from the fighting. It didn't. The deeper damage came from what happened to my sense of reality inside it.

Any time I tried to bring pain into the room, the room turned on me. Grief became selfishness. Confusion became weakness. Panic became immaturity. Need became accusation. If I said I was drowning, I got handed a speech about how someone else had it worse. If I tried to explain what was happening inside me, I walked away feeling more ashamed than I had before I opened my mouth.

That kind of invalidation is not just hurtful. It is instructional.

It teaches you which parts of yourself are unacceptable. It teaches you that honesty will cost you connection. It teaches you to scan your own feelings before you speak and ask not, "Is this true?" but, "Will this get used against me?" Over time, that question becomes your real personality.

I began editing myself before I even spoke. I started shrinking in real time. I learned how to swallow reactions, delay needs, soften truths, and disappear inside conversations that were supposed to be intimate. The safest version of me became the least visible one.

And the kids made that system almost impossible to leave.

That is the piece people can miss if they look at the marriage from the outside and ask why I stayed. They assume I stayed because I believed in the relationship. The truth is uglier and more nervous-system-driven than that. I stayed because my connection to my children had become braided into the relationship's control structure. The thought of losing them did not feel like heartbreak. It felt like annihilation.

Every threat, every separation, every hint that access to my kids could be restricted hit a place in me that was older than reason. It wasn't just fear. It was body terror. A primitive alarm that said: not this, not again, not another bond ripped away.

That is why I kept folding where I should have stood up. Why I kept returning where I should have left. Why boundaries felt less like strength and more like self-amputation.

The most humiliating symbol of that whole period was also the most honest.

I hid in closets.

Not metaphorically. Literally.

There were times I stayed out of sight in my own life because being acknowledged felt more dangerous than being erased. Her family might come around and I would make myself invisible. She could keep me blocked publicly, keep the image she wanted intact, while I physically shrank into whatever hidden space was available. We were married. We had children together. And I was hiding like my existence needed to be managed.

That is not just dysfunction. That is embodiment.

A child who once learned that survival meant being still had grown into a man who could disappear on command if he thought it would preserve attachment. The closet was not a symbol I invented later. It was a room my nervous system recognized immediately.

The marriage did not create my trauma. But it trained it. Refined it. Confirmed it. Every time I was told I was selfish, crazy, too much, weak, or impossible, something old in me nodded and said, Exactly. That is what I have been trying to tell you.

By the end, the worst thing the marriage had taken from me was not peace. It was trust in my own perceptions.

And when a man stops trusting his own perceptions, he becomes easy to steer.

Tina

By the time Tina entered the picture, I was not making decisions from stability. I was making them from collapse.

That distinction matters.

People talk about love like it happens on neutral ground. Like one person stands here, another person stands there, and if the chemistry is right they come together. But a lot of what gets called love does not begin in clarity. Sometimes it begins in emergency. Sometimes it begins when somebody has been starving so long that relief itself starts to feel sacred.

That was the condition I was in.

I was carrying years of shame, years of invalidation, an addiction that had become a regulator, and the growing terror of losing my family structure and what little identity I still had inside it. I was not looking at the world with a steady nervous system and asking who was healthy for me. I was gasping for something that did not feel like drowning.

When a person enters your life at that exact point, your body does not calmly assess them. It lunges.

That is what Tina became to me. Not because she was magic. Not because the relationship itself proved some grand emotional truth. But because she arrived in the middle of collapse, and collapse changes the meaning of attention.

A person who makes room for you when you feel erased can look like salvation. A person who listens when you feel disbelieved can look like destiny. A person who does not immediately trigger the same old terror can feel like proof that rescue is possible.

When you are emotionally starving, relief can feel like love.

That was the hook.

I didn't bond from steadiness. I bonded from panic. The part of me attaching was not the calm adult evaluating what a relationship could actually hold. It was the abandoned part. The flooded part. The part that believed one more loss might split me open for good.

That is why choices made during that period look irrational from the outside. They were not irrational to the nervous system making them. They followed survival logic. Reach for oxygen. Protect the hand holding it. Ignore whatever does not fit the immediate need to stop the internal freefall.

That kind of attachment always carries distortion with it.

Attention gets overread. Availability gets romanticized. Relief gets mistaken for compatibility. The body says, "I can breathe here," and the mind rushes to build a future around that first exhale.

I made Tina larger than reality because I needed her to be larger than reality. I needed the connection to mean something big enough to justify the risk, the disloyalty, the rupture, the emotional velocity. I needed the story to be rescue, because if it wasn't rescue, then maybe it was just another symptom of how desperate I had become.

That is one of the ugliest truths in this whole chapter.

Desperation can make a person feel profound.

Not because the feelings are fake, but because urgency amplifies everything. A starving nervous system is not a reliable narrator. It can take a little bit of warmth and turn it into revelation. It can take temporary relief and declare it destiny. It can mistake a pause in suffering for proof of lifelong safety.

I don't say that to cheapen what Tina was. I say it to tell the truth about what I was.

I was not choosing from freedom. I was choosing from fear.

And fear, when it is dressed up like hope, can be one of the most convincing forces in the world.

Kristina

Kristina hit different because she landed where my mind was weakest.

If Trinity had trained me to doubt myself, and Tina had met me in raw need, Kristina stepped into the territory where being seen and being studied started to blur.

What pulled me in first was recognition.

She seemed to understand things that mattered to me. Reflected interests back at me. Mirrored emotional language in ways that made the connection feel unusually specific. For a person who had spent years feeling erased, that kind of resonance can feel supernatural. It can make you think, finally, somebody gets it. Finally, somebody sees what is under all this static.

But being mirrored is not always the same thing as being known.

Sometimes it is access.

That is part of what took me so long to understand. The parts of me most hungry to be recognized were the same parts most vulnerable to manipulation. If somebody touched that wound the right way, they did not just get my attention. They got my hunger. And hunger is easy to guide.

The confusion in that dynamic did not come only from what she did. It came from how perfectly it meshed with what had already been done to me.

Gaslighting works best when the ground is already unstable.

By the time that relationship formed, I had years of self-doubt behind me. Years of being told I was overreacting. Years of being mislabeled. Years of second-guessing what I felt. Years of assuming the malfunction must be me. So when contradictions showed up, when signals got crossed, when I felt pulled in and pushed away, I did not anchor myself in my own experience. I folded inward and went hunting for what was wrong with me.

That is how a person can end up trapped in confusion that looks invisible from the outside.

You replay conversations. Reconstruct tone. Analyze pauses. Search for hidden meaning in every text and silence. You stop asking, "Is this treatment acceptable?" and start asking, "Why am I so affected by this?" That is a devastating shift because it relocates the whole problem into your own mind while the dynamic keeps cutting you.

The relationship became a hall of mirrors.

I could not tell whether I was seeing clearly or projecting. I could not tell whether I was being mishandled or merely destabilized by my own damage. I kept returning to the very dynamic that was intensifying the confusion in hopes that it would also provide clarity.

That is not connection. That is captivity with emotional language wrapped around it.

But I was not passive in it.

That part matters too.

I brought my own fire into that room. I brought obsession, projection, savior-hunger, abandonment terror, and the impossible demand that another person help me organize pain that had started decades before they arrived. No relationship can safely carry that much historical weight. When it tries, the structure warps. When it fails, the collapse feels cosmic.

Kristina did not create the belief that I was fundamentally broken. She touched it. That was enough.

Once that belief gets activated, everything grows larger than the facts. Every silence starts echoing old abandonment. Every contradiction starts sounding like proof. Every disappointment arrives with the force of history behind it. The present gets drowned by all the rooms it accidentally opened.

That is why the aftermath was so brutal. It was not only heartbreak. It was the further collapse of trust in my own reality.

And once a man loses confidence in his own reality, the whole world becomes harder to stand in.

The Spiral

For a long time, I used these women like evidence in a trial.

See? That's why I used. That's why I ran. That's why I unraveled. That's why I broke.

That explanation was never completely false. Harm happened. Manipulation happened. Invalidating, controlling, and destabilizing dynamics happened. Pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

But if I stop the story there, then all I have done is rename my suffering and hand the power for it entirely to other people.

The more useful truth is harder and less flattering.

The common denominator was me.

Not because I was the villain in every room. Not because every injury was self-inflicted. But because I carried the same unhealed wiring into each relationship and then acted shocked when it produced familiar fires.

That wiring had rules.

When I felt unseen, I latched onto whoever made me feel recognized.

When I felt threatened with abandonment, I reached like separation might kill me.

When I got confused, I assumed I was defective.

When shame flared, I hid.

When panic rose past what my body could regulate, I used.

When using created more shame, I hid harder.

That is the spiral.

Trinity, Tina, and Kristina were not separate detours from the same life. They were three expressions of the same unresolved system trying, failing, and trying again to solve pain through attachment. Each relationship exposed a different feature of the underlying damage: the fear of abandonment, the reflex to disappear, the need to be chosen, the confusion between intensity and safety, and the habit of mistaking relief for love.

What made the spiral so destructive was not just who entered these rooms, but what was already waiting inside them. Old trauma, shame, invalidation, and unregulated fear turned each connection into a test it was never built to pass. Seen that way, the chapter is not just about relational failure. It is about the moment the pattern becomes visible enough to study, name, and eventually interrupt.

For most of my life, I only knew how to think in extremes: it is all their fault or it is all mine. Neither one gets close enough to the truth to be useful.

The truth is that I was wounded and responsible. Manipulated in some places and destructive in others. Capable of being harmed and fully capable of causing harm. Reaching for love with tools built for survival.

That last part is what finally made the pattern legible to me.

I was not entering relationships with actual relational tools. I was entering them with freeze, fawn, shame, hypervigilance, emotional hunger, and chemical coping. Then I expected intimacy to grow out of that soil.

No wonder the roots twisted.

What It Was Really Asking

Under all three of those relationships, one question kept repeating itself in me, even when I did not have language for it:

Can I be close to someone without disappearing?

That was the real question under the marriage. Under the affair. Under the obsession. Under the jealousy. Under the panic. Under the relapses. Under the hiding.

And because I did not know that was the question, I kept answering it with the wrong equipment.

I confused intensity with depth. Relief with safety. Chemistry with rescue. Being studied with being understood. Emotional adrenaline with love.

So I kept stepping into versions of the same fire and telling myself each one was new.

It wasn't new.

It was familiar.

And familiarity has a dangerous way of impersonating home when trauma has been your earliest architecture.

That is why this chapter matters.

Not because Trinity, Tina, and Kristina explain my whole life. Not because they carry all the blame. Not because I want to pin my damage on them and walk away clean.

It matters because once the pattern becomes visible, the collapses stop looking random.

The spiral had logic.

Trauma logic. Survival logic. Nervous-system logic. Twisted, painful, self-defeating logic—but logic all the same.

I was drawn to what activated me more than what steadied me. I trusted intensity more than calm. I kept handing access to wounds I had not yet learned to protect. Then I called the bleeding fate.

It wasn't fate.

It was wiring meeting circumstance again and again.

Turning Toward the Machinery

For a long time, I thought that if I understood this pattern too clearly, all it would do is confirm the ugliest things I already believed about myself. Weak. Broken. Needy. Crazy. Too much. Not enough.

But that is not what happened.

What happened was worse in one way and better in another.

Worse, because I could no longer hide behind randomness. I had to see the repetition. I had to admit I was carrying tinder into every room. I had to stop pretending each fire came from nowhere.

Better, because the pattern gave me something I had almost never had before: a map.

A map does not erase damage. It does not undo betrayals. It does not return lost years, lost trust, or lost versions of yourself.

But it does let you stop wandering blind inside the same wreckage.

Once I could see that the spiral was not random, I could stop spending all my energy asking who struck the match and start asking what in me kept making the rooms so flammable.

That question changed everything.

Not all at once. Not cleanly. Not enough to save what had already burned.

But enough to turn me toward the machinery underneath the story.

Enough to make me understand that if the same wounds kept choosing the same kinds of rooms, then the real work was not just retelling the wreckage.

It was learning the architecture.

Seeing the spiral was only the first step. Naming the pattern didn't fix it, but it stopped me from pretending every collapse was random. The next step wasn't finding better people or begging the past to change. It was turning toward the machinery underneath it all—the blueprint, the wiring, the way my nervous system had been set to danger long before any of these relationships showed up. That's where the fire really started. That's where the next chapter goes.

CHAPTER 10: THE GLASS BOX BLUEPRINT: WIRED FOR DISTANCE AND DANGER

Ground zero. September 1982. Davenport, Iowa. But this chapter isn't just about remembering the start; it's about exploring how that beginning—being born Very Low Birth Weight (VLBW) and spending thirty days in a 1982 Neonatal Intensive Care Unit—might have laid the faulty wiring for the challenges that followed. This is where personal reflection meets the science, trying to understand the connections, give context to the struggles, and maybe find a clearer path toward healing.

They ripped me out too soon. Three pounds, four ounces dropped into a glass box. That incubator stay happened under conditions starkly different from today. Back then, survival was the main goal. Pain management was minimal. Research from the era notes that neonatal surgeries often occurred with little to no anesthesia until the late 1980s (Pain Management in Newborns, PMC). Parental involvement was limited. A 1979 study noted 20% of NICU babies went unvisited by parents for up to a week (Neonatal Intensive Care Unit, Wikipedia). The environment itself was likely bright, noisy, chaotic—a far cry from the womb-like settings aimed for now. My first world wasn't arms and heartbeats; it was acrylic walls, alarms, and distance. I don't have conscious memories, obviously. But my body kept score. That tightness when someone gets close, the hum under fluorescent lights, the persistent feeling of watching life through glass—it all points back. The research suggests VLBW folks face higher risks across several domains:

Anxiety & Stress: Higher likelihood of anxiety disorders, easier overwhelm. (Mood and anxiety disorders in very preterm/very low-birth weight individuals, PubMed)

Mood & Emotion Regulation: Elevated risk for depression, difficulty modulating intense affect.

Attachment & Relationships: Increased rates of insecure attachment, fear of abandonment, relational distrust.

Attention & Executive Function: Greater prevalence of ADHD-like symptoms, organizational difficulty, lower frustration tolerance. (Birth weight as an independent predictor of ADHD symptoms: A within-twin pair analysis, PMC)

Sensory Processing: Hypersensitivity to noise, light, crowds. (Sensory processing patterns of young adults with preterm birth history, PubMed)

Physical Health: Higher long-term risk for hypertension, metabolic syndrome, altered pain thresholds.

Self-Perception: Persistent sense of being “different,” wrestling with the “miracle baby” label.

My life has been a highlight reel of trauma hitting these exact vulnerabilities: witnessing domestic violence as a kid, losing people I loved, the toxic twenty years with Trinity, the manipulative nightmare with Kristina. The severe anxiety, depression, and addiction weren't random; they feel like echoes of that early fight, amplified. My panic attacks starting at seventeen, the sensory overload driving me into isolation—it connects back to that initial stress, that overwhelming environment.

It became a feedback loop. The VLBW vulnerabilities got dialed up by later traumas. Early stress likely primed me for hyperarousal (that constant on edge feeling), making childhood terror hit harder, digging the trenches for Complex PTSD deeper. Addiction wasn't just bad choices; it was desperate self-medication for anxiety and pain rooted way back. Isolation felt safer than the overwhelming world, but it fed the depression. Fear of abandonment led to behaviors that practically guaranteed abandonment, confirming my deepest fear.

Let me simplify it: Think of being born VLBW in that 80s NICU as starting life on shaky ground. When the big storms hit—trauma, loss, toxic relationships—they rocked my foundation harder because it wasn't solid to begin with. Understanding this doesn't excuse the wreckage I caused, especially with my kids. But it shifts the narrative from "I'm fundamentally broken" to "I'm navigating a complex interplay of early vulnerability and later trauma." It dials down the self-blame, just a notch.

The research supports these links. VLBW connections to anxiety, depression, altered stress response, and attachment disruption are empirically validated, though individual outcomes vary significantly based on environment, support, and genetics. Clinical assessments on my end align: severe C-PTSD, depression, addiction. But they also point to resilience, self-awareness. Strengths I didn't see for a long time.

Understanding this VLBW/NICU piece, this blueprint, has been fucking transformative. It reframes my story from one of inherent failure to one of intense, prolonged survival against stacked odds. It doesn't erase the pain I caused or the addiction I still fight daily. But it gives me a different lens—one with a bit more compassion for the kid in the box and the man who emerged. It empowers the healing, leverages the strengths, and maybe, just maybe, offers a flicker of hope to anyone else who started their fight behind glass.

CHAPTER 11: ECHOES AND AMPLIFIERS: WHEN THE BLUEPRINT MEETS THE STORM

Understanding the Glass Box Blueprint—that map of potential vulnerabilities sketched out in my first thirty days—was like finding the architect's flawed plans under the rubble of a collapsed building. It explained the shaky foundation, the predisposition for certain cracks: anxiety, attachment issues, sensory overload, emotional intensity. But a blueprint alone doesn't cause collapse. It takes a storm. Or in my case, a relentless series of them, each one hitting those pre-existing fault lines, making the damage exponentially worse.

This chapter isn't about listing the storms again. You've walked through that wreckage with me. It's about seeing how the blueprint met the storm—how the inherent sensitivities didn't just endure the trauma, loss, and manipulation, but acted like amplifiers, turning manageable waves into tsunamis, sparks into infernos. It's about the echoes of that incubator vibrating through every subsequent trauma, making the ground beneath me perpetually unsteady.

Think back to that six-year-old kid, frozen under a blanket, the sounds of violence cracking the night. The terror was real. But layer on the blueprint: a nervous system likely already humming at a higher frequency from NICU stress, hypersensitive to sound, already prone to anxiety. Did that baseline hyperarousal, that incubator-learned wiring, make the fear penetrate deeper, lodge itself more permanently in my bones? Did the freeze response—a smart survival tactic when movement might mean pain or disruption in that sterile box—become my hardwired default for overwhelming danger? The storm hit, yes. But the blueprint likely dictated the depth of the impact crater. The feeling of needing to be small, quiet, invisible wasn't just a reaction to immediate danger; it was an echo of the incubator's first lesson: Stillness equals survival.

Fast forward to my teens. The crippling social anxiety wasn't just awkwardness. Consider the blueprint's potential for sensory sensitivities—noise, crowds, the inescapable hum of fluorescent lights that always seemed to crawl under my skin. School hallways weren't just busy; they were

an assault. The noise, the bodies brushing past, the fear of judgment—it likely overloaded a system already prone to feeling overwhelmed. That buzzing wasn't just nerves; it felt like the phantom limb pain of connection severed at birth, the echo of NICU alarms creating a constant internal static that made interaction feel dangerous. So I retreated. I sought the back door at Love's years later, haunted Walmart at 2 a.m., isolated myself. And the booze, then the opiates? They weren't just teenage rebellion or poor choices. They were desperate attempts to turn down the volume on that internal and external chaos, self-medication for a nervous system that felt fundamentally incompatible with the world's intensity.

Relationships became the ultimate collision point. The blueprint suggested potential for insecure attachment, a deep-seated fear of abandonment. This wasn't abstract; it was a raw nerve.

When Trinity exerted control, used the kids as leverage, demanded I hide myself—it wasn't just hitting the universal fear of marital problems. It was striking the primal terror learned in the incubator, where connection was inconsistent, mechanical, conditional. Hiding in closets? That was the blueprint screaming: Your needs are dangerous. Your presence causes problems. Disappear. And her cold dismissal after Garrett's death—"Shut up. I have work

tomorrow"—wasn't just shocking lack of empathy. It was the blueprint's deepest fear confirmed in neon lights: In your most profound pain, you are utterly alone. Connection will fail you.

That amplified wound, ripped open by Trinity and rooted in the glass box, set the stage for the devastation of Tina and Kristina. Tina's presence felt like salvation because the abandonment wound, specifically linked to losing my kids, was actively threatening my survival. My desperate need to keep her, selling the Camaro, ignoring red flags, pushing away help—it wasn't love. It was the amplified terror of the blueprint, frantic to avoid re-experiencing that unbearable void. Kristina's manipulation was surgically precise because it targeted the blueprint's weak points. The targeted mirroring—faking interest in my passion—worked because the blueprint felt inherently unseen, dismissed. The gaslighting took hold because the trauma bond's intensity, likely amplified by the blueprint's potential for emotional dysregulation, already had me doubting my own reality. Her diagnosis ("You need therapy") landed because it resonated with the blueprint's quiet, persistent whisper: You are fundamentally different, fundamentally broken. The year of isolation wasn't just grief; it was the blueprint actualized—convinced of my own toxicity, living out the incubator's lesson of distance.

It became a vicious, self-perpetuating cycle. The blueprint's fear of abandonment, amplified by the storm of Trinity's control and the loss of my kids, led to desperate clinging or reactive rage with Tina and Kristina. These reactions, born of amplified panic, often created the very abandonment I feared, which then reinforced the blueprint's core belief: Connection is unsafe. Everyone leaves. The blueprint's anxiety and sensory sensitivity, amplified by the storm of trauma, led to addiction as a coping mechanism. But the addiction became its own storm, creating more loss, more shame, more reasons to feel anxious and flawed, further validating the blueprint's negative self-view.

The storms were real. The violence, the losses, the betrayals, the addiction—they were hurricanes in their own right. But recognizing the Glass Box Blueprint explains why they didn't just damage the house; they leveled it. It wasn't just the force of the storm; it was the storm hitting a foundation built on fault lines. The blueprint amplified the storm's destructive power, and the storm carved the blueprint's flawed design deeper into my being.

Seeing this interplay, this destructive harmony between the blueprint and the storm, doesn't wash away the responsibility for my actions. But it shifts the focus of the blame. It moves it away from the simplistic, shame-based narrative of "I am just inherently fucked up" toward a more complex, compassionate understanding: "This is what happened to a system wired for difficulty from the start, and this is how that system reacted under immense, repeated pressure." It clarifies the real targets for healing—not just the traumatic memories, but the underlying wiring: the hypersensitive nervous system, the insecure attachment patterns, the deep-seated fear of abandonment, the maladaptive survival strategies learned in the glass box and reinforced by every storm since. It's about repairing not just the storm damage, but the foundation itself.

CHAPTER 12: THE ANATOMY OF TRAUMA: 60 REFLECTIONS FROM THE INSIDE

You don't heal trauma by out-talking it. You heal it by out-seeing it. Sixty fragments pulled from the ash. No polish. No apology. Just the mechanics, laid bare.

Survival doesn't ask permission. It rewires you in the dark.

The NICU didn't just keep me alive. It taught my nervous system that connection means wires, alarms, and glass.

Freeze isn't cowardice. It's biology hitting the brakes when flight isn't an option.

Shame thrives in silence. Trauma thrives in it. I fed both for decades.

You don't choose addiction. You choose the nearest thing that turns down the volume.

The brain doesn't store trauma as memory. It stores it as threat protocol.

Hiding in closets wasn't symbolism. It was embodiment. My nervous system finally had a physical shape for how I felt inside.

Grief isn't a wave. It's a tide. It pulls out, leaves wreckage, and comes back heavier.

Meth didn't make me reckless. It made me functional enough to pretend I was okay.

The legal system measures compliance. Trauma measures survival. They speak different languages.

Missing court wasn't defiance. It was a nervous system locked in a room it couldn't find the door to.

You can't outperform a dysregulated nervous system. You just exhaust it faster.

Love bombing isn't love. It's a nervous system hack.

Gaslighting doesn't break you. It breaks your trust in your own data.

I didn't lose my kids to drugs. I lost them to a cascade of unregulated survival responses.

The body keeps score. The mind keeps receipts. The soul keeps the tab.

Catastrophizing isn't paranoia. It's pattern recognition from a life where the worst usually happened.

You don't heal by fixing the past. You heal by upgrading the present wiring.

Addiction is a short-term regulator with long-term collateral damage.

Fawning isn't people-pleasing. It's threat mitigation disguised as compliance.

The first time I said no to a dose, my hands shook. The tenth time, my jaw clenched. The hundredth time, I just breathed.

Trauma doesn't care about your intentions. It cares about your nervous system's baseline.

I thought I was bipolar. I was just drowning in unmetabolized stress.

You can't logic your way out of a physiological state. You have to regulate your way out.
Sleep paralysis isn't a dream. It's the body's brake pedal stuck while the mind's already awake.
The screams at night weren't madness. They were the nervous system blowing a pressure valve.
Isolation feels like safety until you realize it's just a slower bleed.
Work became my new pipe. Cleaner. Legal. Still an escape.
Overperforming isn't discipline. It's panic wearing a suit.
Burnout doesn't announce itself. It just stops showing up one morning.
I didn't need more motivation. I needed a nervous system that didn't treat a Tuesday like a threat.
The mirror lies when shame's in the room. It shows you a monster instead of a mechanic.
You don't break cycles by wishing. You break them by interrupting the reflex.
Forgiveness isn't absolution. It's dropping the hot coal so you can use your hands again.
I didn't fail my kids because I didn't love them. I failed them because I didn't know how to stay regulated while loving them.
Accountability isn't self-flagellation. It's looking at the wreckage and saying, "I built this. I can rebuild it."
Trauma responses aren't flaws. They're outdated software running on modern hardware.
You don't outrun your nervous system. You just give it new terrain to panic on.
The legal freeze wasn't a choice. It was a system collision: court demands vs. biology shutting down.
I stopped asking "Why am I like this?" and started asking "What was this designed to survive?"
The fire didn't destroy me. It revealed what was flammable.
Healing isn't linear. It's a spiral. You pass the same wound with better tools.
You can't regulate through willpower. You regulate through repetition.
The ember isn't hope. It's proof the nervous system can still generate heat without burning everything down.
I didn't need a savior. I needed a co-regulator. A steady pulse to match mine until mine slowed.
Shame shrinks when named. It metastasizes when hidden.
The body doesn't forget. It archives. Therapy just hands you the filing system.
I thought sobriety was the finish line. It's just the starting gate.
You don't heal trauma by erasing it. You heal it by integrating it.
The worst pain isn't the event. It's the years spent blaming yourself for surviving it.
I didn't lose my mind. I lost my baseline.
Connection isn't a cure. It's a calibration tool.
The storm outside doesn't matter if the storm inside never settles.
I stopped fighting my nervous system and started listening to it. That's when the fire cooled.
Accountability without compassion is just shame in a different suit.
You don't rebuild trust with promises. You rebuild it with predictable behavior.
The blueprint isn't destiny. It's a map of where the fault lines are.
I didn't need to be fixed. I needed to be understood. Then I could fix myself.
The ember doesn't need fuel. It just needs space to burn without consuming.
I'm not healed. I'm aligned. And alignment is enough to keep walking.

Chapter 12.5: The Rescue Boat – Why We Reach for Anything That Quiets the Alarm

This ain't about calling addiction a moral failing or some character defect. That's the gaslight version—the story the world loves to tell so it never has to look at the real fire burning underneath. I lived inside that fire for forty-three years. I'm still learning how to live with it. And I see the same pattern in the stories that stay buried, like the 10.7 veterans a day who die by suicide without ever showing up for VA care. Same wiring. Same silence. Same nervous system screaming that connection feels dangerous.

My body learned danger before it learned safety. Three pounds in a glass box, NICU alarms blaring, no mother's touch—just distance, wires, and a priest giving me last rites because they thought I was dying. Then the violence at six: hiding under a thin blanket while screams and breaking glass ripped through the house. My heart pounded like it wanted out of my chest. Freeze became my first language. Hypervigilance became my native tongue. The nervous system doesn't forget those lessons. It stays on high alert, smoke detector glued to the ceiling, blaring at every shadow because tragedy taught it that quiet moments are usually setups for the next hit.

That constant roar—hyperarousal, the body stuck in perpetual fight-flight-freeze—ain't "anxiety" in the cute, manageable way people talk about it. It's a nervous system carved by repeated inescapable threat. The amygdala stays lit. The vagus nerve forgets how to signal safety. The HPA axis pumps stress hormones like they're going out of style. Sleep fractures. Emotions hijack you without warning. The world feels too loud, too close, too dangerous. Fluorescent lights buzz like those old NICU monitors. Crowds feel like judgment. Even closeness can feel like another blanket about to get ripped off.

When that alarm won't shut off, you reach for anything that dials it down long enough to breathe and stay alive another night. That's the rescue boat.

Booze at sixteen to quiet the shakes and make the world feel loose instead of crushing. Pills at seventeen for migraines that felt like my skull splitting open—hydro, Darvocet, morphine, fentanyl patches chewed and shot. Later meth, sometimes injected, sometimes traded for alcohol depending on which demon showed up first. It wasn't about chasing a high for fun. It was about lowering the volume on a nervous system that never learned what "safe enough" felt like.

Society loves to blame the boat. "You're just an addict." "Weak." "Selfish." "Why can't you just stop?" They never ask why the boat launched in the first place. They don't want to look at the storm that made the water so rough you needed anything to keep from drowning. The self-medication wasn't weakness—it was a desperate attempt to survive when the internal fire

got too loud. Substances temporarily boosted GABA, blunted the adrenergic surge, or numbed the emotional flood so I could function, sleep, or just not feel the constant threat for a few hours.

I own the damage I caused. The relapses that hurt my kids—Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, Adalee. The chaos that burned bridges. The times I froze or dissociated instead of showing up. The rage that spilled out when the pressure got too high. But calling it “addiction” as the root problem is the same gaslighting I swallowed for decades. Doctors labeled me bipolar. My ex called me toxic. The system saw defiance when it was freeze. The stigma, the gaslighting, and the stoic “suck it up” culture—whether military or civilian—made everything worse. It told me vulnerability was weakness, asking for help was failure, and my survival strategies proved I was broken. So I hid. I isolated. I didn’t show up.

That’s why so many in that 10.7 group never connect to care. Same CPTSD wiring—prolonged trauma, not single events. Hypervigilance that makes “showing up” feel like walking into another ambush. Avoidance baked into the nervous system. Negative self-concept whispering you’re unworthy or too much. Relational difficulties that make trusting systems or people feel impossible. Disconnection isn’t laziness or defiance. It’s the nervous system doing exactly what it was trained to do: protect by staying distant, by not risking more harm.

I did maybe nine therapy sessions total. Most of what I learned came from writing these books and trying to help other people piece together their own maps. That self-directed grind—researching VLBW/NICU effects, nervous system dysregulation, attachment wounds—shifted the mindset enough that suicidal thoughts lost their grip. Not because the fire went out, but because I stopped asking “Why am I so fucked up?” and started asking “How did I survive this wiring long enough to still be here?”

Purpose grew out of the wreckage. Turning my testimony into something that might help someone else name their storm without the extra weight of shame. That purpose helps too—it gives the days a reason when the alarm starts blaring again.

Understanding the rescue boat as a desperate bid to live—not a moral crime—dials down the self-blame just enough to keep rowing toward calmer water. Regulation comes first now: breathwork, grounding, somatic practices that gently remind the body “safe enough right now.” Then protecting the purpose so helping others doesn’t become another way to disappear from myself.

If you’re carrying this—whether you’re one of the disconnected veterans, a civilian with forty-three years of CPTSD, or anyone whose nervous system never got the all-clear—know this: reaching for the boat doesn’t make you weak. It makes you human trying to survive an injury the world keeps pretending isn’t there. The stigma, the gaslighting, the stoic armor—they’re the real killers of connection. Naming the nervous system truth is how we start dismantling them.

The storm wired us for danger. The fire taught us to burn. But the rescue boat? It was never the enemy. It was proof we still wanted to live.

The ember still burns.

Chapter 12.6: The Second Wound — How Stigma Turns Pain Into Shame

They always made it sound simple.

“It’s all in your head.”

“You’re making yourself worse.”

“Be a man.”

“Grow up.”

“Most people grow up.”

“Aren’t you tired of being a nobody?”

They said it like they were helping.

Like shame was medicine.

Like humiliation was a ladder.

Like if they could just hit the right nerve, I would finally snap out of it, stand up straight, put the past behind me, and become the version of myself they were comfortable with.

But that is not how Complex PTSD works.

That is not how a nervous system heals.

That is not how a man comes back from a lifetime of being wired for danger.

Those words did not make me stronger.

They made me disappear further inside myself.

They took the parts of me that were already bleeding and told them they were embarrassing. They took survival responses I barely understood and turned them into character defects. They took pain that was already heavy and added shame on top of it.

That is the second wound.

The first wound is what happened.

The second wound is what people say about you after it happened.

The first wound is the incubator. The violence. The losses. The marriage. The drugs. The funerals. The closets. The collapse.

The second wound is being told your reaction to all of that means you are weak, selfish, crazy, lazy, immature, toxic, or broken.

The second wound is stigma.

And stigma does not sit outside the body.

It gets in.

It crawls under the skin.

It changes the way you breathe.

It changes the way you look in the mirror.

It changes the way silence sounds.

It makes every mistake feel like proof.

Every missed call feel like rejection.

Every bad day feel like a verdict.

Every setback feel like the final sentence on your life.

That is what people do not understand about direct stigma.

It is not just an insult.

It becomes evidence.

Evidence that you are weak.

Evidence that you are broken.

Evidence that you are too much.

Evidence that nobody is coming.

Evidence that maybe the world would be better off without you in it.

That is where the danger starts.

Not all at once.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

It starts quietly.

A thought.

A sentence.

A small internal surrender.

Maybe they are right.

Maybe I am the problem.

Maybe I am making myself worse.

Maybe I am not a man.

Maybe I am a nobody.

Maybe I am already gone.

“It’s All in Your Head”

People say “it’s all in your head” like that proves it is not real.

But where do they think terror lives?

Where do they think memory lives?

Where do they think panic starts?

Where do they think the alarm system is?

Of course it is in my head.

It is also in my body.

It is in my stomach when it drops for no reason.

It is in my hands when they shake.

It is in my jaw when it locks.

It is in my chest when it tightens.

It is in my sleep when my body refuses to rest.

It is in the way I hear footsteps.

The way I hear a tone change.

The way I notice a door closing too hard.

The way my body knows danger before my mind has words for it.

So yes, it is in my head.

But that does not mean I invented it.

That does not mean I chose it.

That does not mean I can just decide to stop.

Complex PTSD is not imagination.

It is injury.

It is the body remembering what the mind keeps trying to organize.

It is the nervous system treating today like yesterday because yesterday never got resolved.

It is what happens when danger gets repeated so many times that the brain stops asking, "Am I safe?" and starts assuming, "I am not."

When someone says, "It's all in your head," what they are really saying is, "I do not want to understand this."

And when you hear that enough, you stop trying to explain.

You stop reaching.

You stop correcting people.

You stop saying, "No, this is real."

You begin to wonder if maybe you are crazy.

That is how stigma works.

It does not have to prove anything.

It only has to make you doubt yourself.

"You're Making Yourself Worse"

This one always sounded like responsibility.

"You're making yourself worse."

Like I was standing there with a shovel, digging my own grave on purpose.

Like I enjoyed the panic.

Like I enjoyed depression.

Like I enjoyed destroying good things.

Like I enjoyed being late, frozen, reactive, exhausted, ashamed, and trapped in my own skin.

People love to point at the pattern after it has already become a problem.

They do not ask where it came from.

They do not ask what it protected.

They do not ask what it cost to survive before I ever had better tools.

Avoidance made sense when facing things meant being overwhelmed.

Isolation made sense when people were unsafe.

Anger made sense when softness got used against me.

Numbing made sense when feeling everything would have killed me.

Workaholism made sense when stopping meant hearing the screams inside my own head.

Substances made sense when my nervous system was fighting for its life and nothing else reached it fast enough.

That does not mean those things were healthy.

That does not mean they did not hurt people.

That does not mean I get to hide behind trauma and never change.

But it does mean those patterns were not random.

They were not proof that I did not care.

They were not proof that I chose chaos over family.

They were not proof that I wanted to be broken.

They were survival strategies that stayed past their expiration date.

That is the part people miss.

A thing can save you once and destroy you later.

A thing can keep you alive in one season and keep you trapped in the next.

That is why healing is so hard.

You are not just giving up bad habits.

You are letting go of the only things that once kept you alive.

So when someone says, "You're making yourself worse," they may be pointing at something real, but they are saying it in the most damaging way possible.

Because shame does not teach a nervous system safety.

Shame teaches hiding.

Shame teaches lying.

Shame teaches silence.

Shame teaches relapse.

Shame teaches the body that people are still dangerous.

A better sentence would have been:

"I can see this is hurting you now, even if it helped you survive before."

That sentence leaves a door open.

The other one shuts it.

“Be a Man”

Nothing has killed more men quietly than that phrase.

Be a man.

Three words.

A whole prison.

It means do not cry.

Do not shake.

Do not admit fear.

Do not say you are lonely.

Do not say you are drowning.

Do not say you miss your kids.

Do not say you are ashamed.

Do not say the memories still own parts of you.

Do not say you need help.

Do not say you are scared of what you might do if the pain does not stop.

Just work.

Provide.

Shut up.

Take it.

Drink it down.

Smoke it down.

Work it off.

Fight it out.

Laugh it off.

Be useful.

Be hard.

Be silent.

And if silence starts killing you, at least die without making anyone uncomfortable.

That is what “be a man” really teaches.

It does not create strength.

It creates emotional starvation.

It teaches boys to become men who cannot name their pain until it comes out sideways.

Rage.

Addiction.

Withdrawal.

Control.

Self-destruction.

A body always braced for war.

A mouth that says “I’m fine” while the soul crawls toward the edge.

I spent so much of my life trying to look okay that I did not know how to tell the truth without feeling weak.

I thought being strong meant needing nothing.

I thought being a man meant carrying everything alone.

I thought if I could just work harder, hurt quieter, and keep moving, maybe nobody would notice how bad it was inside me.

But C-PTSD does not disappear because a man refuses to cry.

It goes underground.

It grows teeth.

It waits.

Then it comes out in the parts of life he wanted most to protect.

His marriage.

His children.

His work.

His body.

His faith.

His ability to sleep.

His ability to feel joy without fear.

“Be a man” did not save me.

It helped bury me.

Real manhood is not silence.

Real manhood is not pretending pain does not exist.

Real manhood is facing the truth without running from it.

It is apologizing.

It is healing.

It is staying alive.

It is letting someone see the wound before the wound becomes a weapon.

A man asking for help is not failing at being a man.

He is refusing to let shame write the ending.

“Grow Up”

People say “grow up” when they think the problem is maturity.

But trauma does not care how old you are.

You can be grown and still carry a terrified child inside your nervous system.

You can have bills, jobs, kids, responsibilities, and gray in your beard, and still have parts of you frozen in rooms nobody ever rescued you from.

That is not childish.

That is trauma.

There were parts of me that grew up too fast.

Parts that learned to read danger before I learned to feel safe.

Parts that learned to survive adults before I knew how to be a child.

Parts that learned to keep going no matter what.

But there were other parts that never got to grow right.

Parts that never learned trust.

Parts that never learned secure love.

Parts that never learned how to calm down after fear.

Parts that never learned that conflict does not always mean abandonment.

Parts that never learned that rest is safe.

Parts that never learned that I could be loved without performing, pleasing, fixing, or proving.

So when someone says, "Grow up," they are talking to a wound like it is a bad attitude.

They are yelling at a survival state.

They are shaming the part of a person that actually needs the most care.

That does not mean adults with C-PTSD have no responsibility.

I am responsible for what I do now.

I am responsible for healing.

I am responsible for repair.

I am responsible for learning different responses.

I am responsible for not using my wounds as permission to wound others.

But responsibility without compassion turns into punishment.

And punishment is not healing.

A better sentence would have been:

“You are an adult now, and you deserve help healing the parts of you that had to survive too early.”

That sentence tells the truth.

It does not excuse.

It does not shame.

It gives the grown man and the wounded child a way to exist in the same body without hating each other.

“Aren’t You Tired of Being a Nobody?”

That one goes straight for the soul.

“Aren’t you tired of being a nobody?”

As if I had not already asked myself that in a thousand different ways.

As if I had not already looked at my life and counted the wreckage.

As if I had not already measured myself against other men and found myself behind.

Behind in money.

Behind in stability.

Behind in family.

Behind in peace.

Behind in reputation.

Behind in everything I thought I was supposed to be by now.

A person with C-PTSD does not need help feeling like a failure.

Most of us already have that covered.

We carry invisible scoreboards in our heads.

Every lost job.

Every relapse.

Every broken relationship.

Every missed chance.

Every person we hurt.

Every person who left.

Every time we said, "This time will be different," and then watched the same fire start again.

So when someone says, "Aren't you tired of being a nobody?" they think they are lighting a fire under you.

They do not realize they are pouring gasoline on shame.

Because the real wound is not laziness.

It is grief.

Grief for the life that might have been.

Grief for the person I could have become if I had not spent so many years surviving.

Grief for the father I wanted to be.

Grief for the husband I failed to be.

Grief for the son, brother, friend, worker, and man I kept trying to become while dragging a war behind me.

Calling someone a nobody does not motivate them.

It confirms the lie trauma already planted.

That their life has no weight.

That their existence is a burden.

That they are only visible when they fail.

No one heals by being convinced they are worthless.

People heal when they can believe there is still something in them worth saving.

Shame: The Wound Under the Wound

Guilt says, "I did something wrong."

Shame says, "I am wrong."

That difference matters.

Guilt can lead to repair.

Shame leads to hiding.

Guilt can say, "I need to make this right."

Shame says, "I ruin everything I touch."

Guilt can lead a man to apologize.

Shame can lead him to disappear.

And C-PTSD is full of shame.

Not normal shame.

Not the kind that passes after a mistake.

Deep shame.

Identity shame.

The kind that says your very existence is a problem.

The kind that started before you had words.

The kind that came from being hurt, then blamed.

Neglected, then called needy.

Controlled, then called difficult.

Abused, then told to keep quiet.

Broken, then told you were too sensitive.

That kind of shame does not leave just because time passes.

It becomes the voice inside your head.

Then direct stigma gives that voice a microphone.

"It's all in your head."

See? Your pain is fake.

"You're making yourself worse."

See? This is your fault.

"Be a man."

See? You are weak.

"Grow up."

See? You are pathetic.

"Aren't you tired of being a nobody?"

See? Your life does not matter.

That is how outside voices become inside voices.

That is how people who harmed you keep speaking through people who never even knew the original wound.

That is why words matter.

Because some words do not just hurt.

They install themselves.

Guilt: The Weight That Turns Against You

Guilt is complicated.

Some guilt is real.

I have hurt people.

I have failed people.

I have made choices that caused damage.

I have reacted from wounds and left wounds in others.

I cannot pretend that did not happen.

Trauma explains some of it.

It does not erase the impact.

That is the hard truth.

But there is another kind of guilt that trauma creates.

False guilt.

The guilt of believing you should have been able to stop what happened to you.

The guilt of believing you should have left sooner.

The guilt of believing you should have fought harder.

The guilt of believing you should have known better as a child.

The guilt of believing you are responsible for everyone's pain.

The guilt of needing help.

The guilt of not being healed fast enough.

The guilt of surviving in ugly ways.

Stigma mixes real guilt and false guilt together until a person cannot tell the difference.

Then guilt stops being a signal for repair.

It becomes a sentence.

It says:

"You have done too much damage."

"You cannot come back from this."

"You do not deserve forgiveness."

"Everyone would be better off without you."

That last sentence is where guilt becomes deadly.

Because suicidal thinking often does not arrive wearing the face of death.

Sometimes it arrives wearing the face of logic.

It tells you it would be merciful to leave.

It tells you your absence would be a gift.

It tells you you have become too heavy for everyone else to carry.

It tells you disappearing would finally make the pain stop.

That is not truth.

That is shame talking in a calm voice.

That is guilt after it has been poisoned.

That is stigma after it has moved inside the bloodstream.

When Stigma Becomes Suicidal Pain

Nobody wants to talk about this part directly.

But we have to.

Direct stigma can push a person closer to suicide.

Not always by itself.

Not like one sentence automatically does it.

But when those sentences stack on top of years of trauma, grief, isolation, addiction, rejection, exhaustion, and self-hatred, they can become part of the weight that breaks a person.

A man with C-PTSD may already be tired in a way sleep cannot fix.

He may already be fighting memories he cannot explain.

He may already be carrying regret that eats him alive.

He may already feel like he lost too much time.

He may already believe his family sees only the worst parts of him.

He may already think his children will never understand.

He may already feel like his name has been ruined.

He may already feel like every attempt to get better ends with him back in the same hole.

Then someone says:

“Be a man.”

“Grow up.”

“You’re making yourself worse.”

“Aren’t you tired of being a nobody?”

And something inside him folds.

Not because he is weak.

Because he was already carrying too much.

People think suicide is always a loud crisis.

Sometimes it is quiet.

Sometimes it is a man sitting alone, staring at nothing, feeling like he has already become a ghost.

Sometimes it is him laughing with people during the day and fighting not to die at night.

Sometimes it is him making jokes because honesty would scare everyone.

Sometimes it is him saying, “I’m tired,” and nobody hears what he means.

Sometimes it is him believing that staying alive has become an inconvenience to everyone else.

That is why stigma is dangerous.

It does not just judge pain.

It isolates pain.

And isolated pain starts looking for an exit.

If you are reading this and you know that place, hear me clearly:

You do not have to fix your whole life tonight.

You do not have to solve every regret.

You do not have to become who you were supposed to be before morning.

You only have to stay.

One breath.

One minute.

One phone call.

One door between you and the weapon.

One message to someone who can sit with you.

One call to 988 if you are in the United States.

One moment of not letting shame make the final decision.

The part of you that wants the pain to stop is not your enemy.

But death is not the only way pain stops.

Healing is slower.

Messier.

Harder.

But it leaves you here to see what can still be rebuilt.

The Lie of Tough Love

A lot of people hide cruelty behind “tough love.”

They say, “I’m just being honest.”

But honesty without compassion is often just violence with better manners.

Real tough love has boundaries.

Fake tough love has contempt.

Real tough love says:

“I love you, but I will not enable what is destroying you.”

Fake tough love says:

“You are pathetic.”

Real tough love says:

“What you did hurt me, and it has to change.”

Fake tough love says:

“You are nothing.”

Real tough love says:

“Your trauma matters, but so does your responsibility.”

Fake tough love says:

“Stop using trauma as an excuse.”

Real tough love leaves a path forward.

Fake tough love leaves a person standing in shame with nowhere to go.

That is the difference.

People with C-PTSD do not need lies.

They do not need coddling.

They do not need everyone pretending the damage is not real.

They need truth.

But truth does not have to strip a person of dignity.

Truth does not have to spit on the wound.

Truth does not have to make a man feel like dying is the only honorable thing left.

Accountability Without Dehumanization

This is where people get scared.

They think if we understand trauma, we excuse everything.

No.

Understanding is not excusing.

Explanation is not permission.

Compassion is not a blank check.

A person with C-PTSD can still cause harm.

A person with C-PTSD can still lie, rage, use, avoid, manipulate, abandon, or destroy trust.

Those things have to be faced.

But they have to be faced in a way that does not turn the person into garbage.

There is a way to say:

"You hurt me."

without saying:

"You are worthless."

There is a way to say:

"You need help."

without saying:

"You are crazy."

There is a way to say:

"I cannot live in this chaos."

without saying:

"You are impossible to love."

There is a way to say:

"You are responsible for healing."

without saying:

"Your wound is your fault."

That difference can save lives.

Because shame does not create accountability.

Shame creates defense.

Shame creates collapse.

Shame creates secrecy.

Shame creates relapse.

Shame creates the belief that repair is impossible.

Accountability says:

“You did harm. Now take the next right step.”

Stigma says:

“You are harm.”

One gives a person a road.

The other gives them a grave.

What People Should Have Said

They could have said:

“I do not fully understand what is happening inside you, but I believe it is real.”

They could have said:

“I can see you are stuck in patterns that are hurting you, and I want you to get help.”

They could have said:

“You do not have to hide pain to prove you are a man.”

They could have said:

“You are grown now, and you are responsible for healing, but I know the wound started before you had control.”

They could have said:

“You are not a nobody. You are wounded. You are stuck. You are still here. That means something.”

They could have said:

“I will not excuse harmful behavior, but I will not shame you for being injured.”

They could have said:

“What happened to you matters.”

They could have said:

“What you do next matters too.”

They could have said:

“Stay.”

Sometimes one word matters.

Stay.

Not “get over it.”

Not “man up.”

Not “stop being dramatic.”

Stay.

Stay long enough to feel something different.

Stay long enough to learn what safety feels like.

Stay long enough to repair what can be repaired.

Stay long enough to become someone you have not met yet.

Stay long enough for your children to one day understand more than they understand right now.

Stay long enough for your nervous system to learn that the war is not the whole story.

What Stigma Stole

Stigma stole time.

It stole language.

It stole help.

It stole trust.

It made me think pain was weakness.

It made me think needing people was dangerous.

It made me think my symptoms were proof that I was defective.

It made me hide the truth until the truth came out sideways.

It made me apologize for being wounded before I even understood the wound.

It made me believe I had to earn the right to be treated like a human being.

That is what stigma does.

It does not just misunderstand trauma.

It extends it.

It becomes another unsafe room.

Another accusing voice.

Another reason not to reach out.

Another reason to stay silent.

Another reason to die quietly.

And I am done pretending that is harmless.

The Truth

The truth is, C-PTSD is not weakness.

It is not immaturity.

It is not drama.

It is not a man refusing to grow up.

It is not someone making himself worse because he enjoys suffering.

It is what happens when survival gets wired so deeply that peace feels foreign.

It is what happens when the body learns danger before it learns safety.

It is what happens when shame becomes the language a person speaks to himself.

And healing does not come from more shame.

Healing comes from truth with dignity.

Accountability with compassion.

Boundaries without cruelty.

Support without control.

Responsibility without humiliation.

A person with C-PTSD does not need the world to pretend he has caused no harm.

He needs the world to understand that harm and wound can live in the same body.

He needs someone to say:

“You are responsible for what you do next.”

and also:

“You are not beyond saving.”

Because sometimes that is the sentence that keeps a person alive.

Not “be a man.”

Not “grow up.”

Not “you’re a nobody.”

This:

“You are not beyond saving.”

And for a man who has spent his whole life believing shame was the final truth, that sentence can become the first crack of light.

Updated Table of Contents placement

Use this:

PART IV: DECODING THE FIRE

Chapter 9: Decoding the Fire: Shifting the Blame

Chapter 10: The Glass Box Blueprint: Wired for Distance and Danger

Chapter 11: Echoes and Amplifiers: When the Blueprint Meets the Storm

Chapter 12: The Anatomy of Trauma: 60 Reflections from the Inside

Chapter 12.5: The Rescue Boat — Why We Reach for Anything That Quiets the Alarm

Chapter 12.6: The Second Wound — How Stigma Turns Pain Into Shame

Then Part V starts after that:

PART V: RECKONING AND RISING

Chapter 13: Conversations at Midnight

Chapter 14: Letters of Healing

Chapter 15: The Ember Still Burns

Chapter 16: From the Wreckage to the Rising Flame

This makes the book flow clean: **story** → **mechanics** → **stigma** → **reckoning** → **healing**.

CHAPTER 13: CONVERSATIONS AT MIDNIGHT

The silence of the late hours hits different when you've spent the day performing normal.

One of those nights where the walls feel closer, the quiet gets loud, and you reach for something—anything—to untangle the wires in your head. What starts as a quiet exchange with yourself turns into a reckoning. No audience. No script. Just the truth, stripped bare.

It started with trying to connect. I poured months into a video. Creativity, energy, everything I had left. Showed it to the people I cared about most. Silence. Teaguen said he had no time.

Shayla brushed it off like it didn't matter.

Then the songs. Written for her. Better than the noise on the radio. Meant to say what I couldn't out loud. Unheard. Unacknowledged.

That hurt. Not because of the work. Because of what it meant.

A need to be seen. To be understood. To matter.

My brain twisted the indifference into proof. You don't matter. You're too much. You're broken.

That old tape, playing on loop. I started believing it. Again.

But as I spoke—actually spoke, out loud to the empty room—something shifted.

Vulnerability isn't weakness. It's exposure. And exposure is how you stop lying to yourself.

My tears weren't failure. My need for connection wasn't pathetic. They were just proof the nervous system hadn't flatlined yet.

I talked about the loops. The way my mind traps me in fear, tells me not to reach out, not to risk dragging someone else into the smoke. It's the blueprint again: Shut down before they leave.

Protect yourself by disappearing first.

There's a woman I wanted to talk to. She seemed interested. My brain screamed: Abort. You'll ruin it. You'll hurt her. Walk away.

So I did. I broke my own heart trying to save hers.

It's hard to admit that. Hard to sit with the shame of a 42-year-old man fighting invisible battles, crying too often, asking for space to breathe and getting indifference. Three people last year told me I didn't matter. For a while, I believed them.

But tonight's silence reminded me: emotions aren't flaws. They're data. They're proof I'm still processing. Still human. Still in the fight.

The guilt eats at me, especially with the kids. I'm torn between begging for their love and building a wall so the next rejection doesn't crack my ribs. I wonder if moving forward means pretending they never existed. If that's the only way to stop the bleeding. I can't. The heart doesn't work like that. It still beats for them. Even in absence. Even in silence. So how do you keep going? Maybe the answer lives in the space between surrender and stubbornness. Between grief and refusal. Moving forward doesn't mean erasing them or the damage. It means learning to carry both without letting either crush you. Building a life where love, regret, healing, and hope can share the same room. Tonight, I reminded myself: I'm not perfect. I'm trying. I'm flawed. I'm real. And even in the dark, there's light in the willingness to look. Strength in the refusal to quit. Hope in the parts that still want to connect. This isn't just reflection. It's a contract with myself. To keep fighting. To keep creating. To keep loving, even when it's hard. To keep going.

CHAPTER 14: LETTERS OF HEALING

Note: These aren't apologies. They're acknowledgments. Written to stop the loop, own the mechanics, and release the weight so the work can actually move forward.

To My Children (Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, Adalee)

I've spent too long letting the chaos inside me spill onto you. I'm sorry. This isn't an excuse. It's an explanation of the storm I carried and how it hurt you. You deserved a steady, present, safe father. Too often, I wasn't that.

From early on, my nervous system learned to brace for impact. Violence, loss, instability—it layered into a belief that I had to handle everything alone, that pain meant escape, that imperfection meant worthlessness. Those lies drove my mistakes: yelling, disappearing into substances, failing to show up. I thought hiding my pain protected you. It didn't. It isolated you. I hurt you, and I carry that daily.

Therapy and hard truth have stripped those lies down. Life isn't fair, but I'm learning to take the hit without breaking. Showing how I feel isn't weakness; it's how connection works. My worth isn't tied to my failures. Yours isn't either. I'm learning to regulate the fire so it doesn't burn you again.

You are my heart. My biggest regret is the pain I caused. My deepest hope is to rebuild. I don't expect trust overnight. I'm committed to earning it, day by day, by showing up honest, steady, and present. If you're angry or hurt, that's valid. I'm here when you're ready.

My fight is mine. But your existence is the fuel. I'm fighting for a future where I can be the father you deserved. You are never to blame for my struggles. I love you more than words can hold. Always.

To Trinity

I'm writing this with clarity carved from years of therapy and nights choking on the ash of twenty years. This isn't about crucifying you or groveling. It's about naming the damage, owning my side, and burning the resentment so I can breathe for myself and our kids.

I came to you already fractured. NICU wiring, childhood violence, abandonment fear—I dragged that live wire into our marriage. We didn't build a partnership; we built a pressure cooker. I wasn't a saint. My rage detonated. I clung to substances when the pain roared louder than my coping skills. My oldest saw me breaking and asked why I stayed. I thought I hid it. Kids don't miss it. My choices poisoned your home. I'm gutted for failing them. For failing you.

But you weren't just collateral. You weaponized my fear. Used the kids as leverage. Kept them from me for years. Told them I chose drugs over them. That's a lie. Relapse isn't a preference; it's a nervous system screaming for equilibrium. C-PTSD doesn't make you narcissistic; it makes you convinced you're worthless. When I showed pain, you flipped it to yours. When I broke after Garrett's death, you told me to shut up. That wasn't just cold. It was erasure. Hiding in closets to keep your family's approval wasn't humiliation. It was confirmation of the NICU's first lesson: Your presence is a problem. Disappear. Rehab in 2015 wasn't care; it was control. The divorce, the legal fallout, the courtroom purgatory—it all echoed the same message: you don't get to be here.

We fed each other's wounds. I own my part: the rage, the addiction, the failure to regulate. I'm sick with regret for the pain I caused Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, Adalee. Therapy showed me it's C-PTSD, not Bipolar. The wiring drove the spirals. Substances were a flawed escape, not a choice to hurt anyone.

I'm not asking for apologies or a rewrite. I'm owning my side so the resentment stops eating me alive. I see you as human, scarred by your own unseen wars. I'm fighting for sobriety, rewiring my brain, building a life that isn't ash. My kids are my north star. I'm clawing to be the father I owed them. I don't expect friendship. I'm asking for basic respect in co-parenting, not a war that keeps them from their dad. I'm burning the slaughterhouse to the ground. Walking into a future forged in healing, not hate.

To Kristina

Williston was a whirlwind that left me shattered. You came when I was raw—grieving my mom, my marriage, my kids. Your attention felt like a lifeline. You said, "I'm different." For a moment, I believed it.

Your withdrawal, the gaslighting, the calculated distance—it hit wounds I didn't know were open. I reacted horribly. Rage texts. Cruel words. Self-harm to cope with the spiral. I lost focus at work. I pushed toward therapy I wasn't ready for. I'm not proud of that desperation.

I used to think I couldn't survive abandonment, that you owed me loyalty, that hurting you would ease the pain. Those were lies rooted in a childhood of fear and a nervous system wired for panic. Therapy's shown me pain isn't unbearable. I've survived worse. Your manipulation was real, but my reactions were mine, driven by old wounds you knew how to press. I regret the harm I caused. The chaos I added.

I'm not here to ask for forgiveness. I'm owning my part and letting go of the anger. Your actions don't define me. I'm in therapy. Fighting for sobriety. Learning to handle emotion without destruction. My focus is on healing and being the dad my kids deserve. I hope you find your own peace.

To My Younger Self (Age 6)

I see you under that blanket. Hearing Mom scream. Heart hammering. It's not your fault. You're just a kid in a terrifying storm.

Back then, you learned to survive: Fear is too big. You're to blame. Stay small and silent. This will never end. Those thoughts made sense for a scared kid in danger. They aren't truth. Fear won't break you. The violence isn't your fault. Staying quiet kept you safe then, but you aren't helpless now. And that storm passes.

That terror wired you for fear, from the NICU to those nights of violence. It's why you feel everything so deeply. But that wiring doesn't define you. You aren't weak for freezing. You're tough as hell for making it through. The relief you felt when that man died? That's okay. It was your nervous system saying you deserved safety.

You'll carry this pain for a while. But you'll learn to set it down. You'll find ways to feel fear without hiding, to love without bracing for loss. Keep going. You've got a heart that won't quit. I'm proud of you for surviving.

To My Addiction

You entered as relief. You stayed as wreckage. You felt like a friend. You became a master. I didn't have the tools to handle the anxiety, the sensory overload, the unprocessed grief. You offered a way out. A temporary silencing of the storm. You felt like survival. But you lied. You didn't solve the pain; you buried it. You demanded everything: money, relationships, integrity, health, identity. You isolated me. You fueled the chaos. You stood between me and my kids. My reliance on you was my choice. Born of desperation. A nervous system overwhelmed. A mind lacking healthier coping strategies. I chose you over discomfort, over feeling, over responsibility. I chose you even when I knew you were killing me, because facing the pain you masked felt more terrifying than the wreckage you created.

Through therapy and recovery, I see you now. Not as a moral failure, but as a maladaptive coping mechanism tied directly to trauma. You exploited my pain, my wiring, my lack of tools. You were a symptom that became a disease. The fight against you is daily. A constant battle against ingrained patterns and the urge to return to false comfort when stress hits.

I'm looking you in the eye and declaring I see you for what you are. I acknowledge the hold you had. I acknowledge the ongoing fight. But I'm no longer defining myself by you. My focus is on building a life resilient enough to face pain without your escape. Learning to regulate. To connect. To fight for sobriety, fueled by the life I'm building and the love for my kids you tried to extinguish. I'm releasing your grip, one day at a time. The fight continues. I'm no longer yours.

CHAPTER 15: THE EMBER STILL BURNS

For a long time, I thought I'd lost the one thing that used to make me me. My heart. Not the muscle. The part that made me want to give, to protect, to love even when I didn't get it back. Somewhere between the wreckage of my marriage, the manipulation I mistook for salvation, and the year I spent convinced I was clinically broken... I forgot I ever had a heart worth keeping.

They handed me a Borderline Personality Disorder label. I wore it like a brand. Apologized for every feeling. Every memory. Every desperate reaction. I isolated for a year, grieving a self I thought was fractured beyond repair. I told my kids. I wrote pages trying to rationalize it. I told the world: This is why I am the way I am.

Then, two minutes into a real therapy session, my therapist looked at me and said: "You don't have BPD. You're not crazy. She manipulated you."

The floor dropped. Again.

At first, relief. Then the guilt hit hard. If I wasn't broken, what did that make my twenty-year marriage? What did it make all the times I pointed the finger at Trinity, blaming her control, her coldness, her emotional games for the wreckage? If I wasn't fundamentally damaged, maybe I was the architect. Maybe I burned it down.

But truth doesn't live in the extremes. It lives in the messy middle.

Trinity did turn my kids against me. She did use them as leverage. She did make me feel invisible in my own home, hiding me in closets like I was something to be ashamed of. Kristina did gaslight me. She did pull me in, then push me away, over and over, until I truly thought I'd lost my grip on reality.

And yet... somewhere deep down, I still felt something for them. Not trust. Not longing.

Something softer than hate.

Saying "I hate them" was never the truth. It was armor. It was survival. It was my last defense against a world that kept proving connection was dangerous.

Tonight, I remembered something important—maybe the most important thing.

I still have a heart. And it still wants to love.

I'm tired of pretending I don't care when I do. I buried it under rage, grief, and self-protection.

Tried to kill it with silence, with "fuck them" and "fuck me." But it never died. It just waited. For this version of me. The one rewriting his own story because the old script no longer fits.

The black-and-white thinking told me they're either good or evil, and I'm either the villain or the victim. That's not real life. That's trauma talking. Real life is full of people who are flawed, faltering, and scared. People who hurt each other not because they're monsters, but because they're broken, or never taught how to love without controlling.

Albert Ellis put it plainly: "People are fallible. Accept it."

That includes Trinity. That includes Kristina. That includes me.

Maybe I'll never get my kids back on the terms I used to imagine. Maybe the damage runs too deep for full repair right now. But remembering I still have a heart means I can start living like I do. Not for them. Not for her. For me.

Because the fire didn't destroy everything. The ember still burns.

CHAPTER 16: FROM THE WRECKAGE TO THE RISING FLAME

For a long time, I didn't know what was left after the storm passed. The violence, the chaos, the constant state of emergency—it felt like it leveled everything. Just rubble and ash where a life

was supposed to be. And in the middle of it, I stood, dazed, instinctively looking for someone to blame. They did this. Their actions, their failures, their cruelty. It was easier than looking at the structural flaws in the foundation I'd built, or worse, the damage I'd inflicted myself while flailing in the tempest.

Blame was a shield. A twisted kind of comfort. If it was all their fault, I was just a victim. It meant I didn't have to look at how my own trauma had warped my responses, how I'd recreated the storm in new relationships, how my desperate need for safety had manifested as control, anger, or pushing people away before they could leave. It meant I didn't have to confront the possibility that I had hurt people too—sometimes out of malice born of pain, sometimes just out of pure, ignorant dysfunction.

The letters in Chapter 14 were a necessary start. They forced me to name the pain inflicted on me. But they were still heavy with accusation, weighted with the unspoken demand for recognition of my suffering. Planting me firmly in the wreckage phase. The rising couldn't begin until I shifted my gaze inward.

Th therapy, the real, deep-dive, gut-wrenching kind, has been the relentless force pushing me to make that shift. It's like being forced to sift through the rubble of your own collapsed building, piece by piece. Every piece is sharp. You cut your hands on broken glass, choke on denial, stumble over the twisted rebar of your own flawed coping mechanisms. The therapist doesn't rebuild it for you. They just hand you the gloves and stand by while you do the work.

One of the hardest truths I had to pick up was how I used people. How I projected onto them. How I saw them not as complex, fallible human beings, but as roles in my own internal drama. The rescuer I desperately needed. The abuser I feared. The mirror reflecting back the worthlessness I felt inside. I put the impossible burden of healing me onto others, and when they buckled under the weight—because no one can carry another person's entire trauma history—I resented them for failing. Then, in my twisted logic, they became the new source of pain, confirming my belief that everyone eventually hurts me.

A few days ago, on May 11, 2025—Mother's Day—I sat down and wrote to Kristina. Not a letter like the ones I poured out before. Not some carefully constructed explanation or demand. Just a few lines, raw and real, sent into the void because it felt like something I had to do. Prompted by that ongoing internal work. Here's exactly what I wrote:

Happy Mother's Day. I hope you are doing good. I'm learning a lot in therapy. I'm sorry I threw everything at you from my past, expecting you to be my savior and blaming you for all of my past. I'm sorry.

It's not poetry. It's not enough to undo the hurt we caused each other. But it's a step. A small one, yes, but monumental for me. Sending that email wasn't about getting her forgiveness or rewriting our shared history. It was about me standing in front of the mirror, seeing the man who, out of his own agony, played a significant part in turning our connection into another damn storm. I expected her to single-handedly heal a lifetime of complex wounds—NICU trauma, childhood violence, abandonment, loss, addiction, the whole heavy suitcase—and when she couldn't, when she understandably faltered under that impossible expectation, I lashed out. Therapy showed me that's not love. It's desperation wearing a disguise.

Finally apologizing for my part in that dynamic, even in clumsy words, was my way of saying: I see it now. I'm trying to do better. I'm trying to be accountable.

Writing it felt like reaching down into the wreckage, picking up a sharp piece of my own misplaced blame, turning it over in my hands, acknowledging its weight, and then consciously setting it down. Not because she responded. She might not. In the grand scheme, that's okay now. But because it was me choosing to act from a place of truth and accountability, rather than reacting from old pain and resentment.

It's what I want, more than anything, for Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, and Adalee: a dad who owns his shit. Who doesn't let the fire of his past trauma burn everyone else down with him. I can't change the past we shared, but I can change what I carry into their future.

Laying this all bare wasn't just about recounting events or listing grievances. It started as a silent scream—a desperate, guttural need to give voice to decades of chaos, confusion, and pain held inside my body, inside my mind. Putting words to the wreckage, pulling memories and emotions from the rubble one by one, was the only way to begin untangling the why behind the constant burn.

And in the process of sifting through the ash, I found the ember. It's small. Sometimes buried deep. Sometimes just a faint glow. But it's there. The part of me that survived, yes, but also the part that can learn, that can feel, that can connect, that can take responsibility, that can rise. It's not about erasing the past or pretending the damage isn't real. It's about finding the strength within the wreckage to build something new.

This chapter, these words, this painful sifting... this is where the focus shifts. From the storm that hit me, to the wreckage it left behind, to the painstaking work of finding the ember within. The rising hasn't happened yet, not fully. But the flame? The flame is starting to stir.

Chapter 17: My Body Kept the Score

People love saying trauma is in your head.

Like that means it ain't real.

Like if they can't see blood, stitches, bruises, or broken bones, then the damage must be imaginary.

"It's all in your head."

No.

It's in my head, yeah.

But it's also in my chest.

My gut.

My blood pressure.

My blood sugar.

My hormones.

My sleep.

My sex drive.

My energy.

My jaw.

My breathing.

My skin under fluorescent lights.

My legs when they won't move.

My brain when it goes blank under pressure.

My stomach when dread drops through me before I even know what triggered it.

Complex PTSD doesn't just give you bad memories.

It turns the whole body into a fire alarm that never got the all-clear.

And if that alarm keeps ringing long enough, parts start burning out.

For years, I treated the physical stuff like bad luck.

High blood pressure.

Diabetes.

Low testosterone.

Migraines.

Gut problems.

Sleep apnea.

Fatigue.

Brain fog.

Panic that felt electrical.

A body that felt older than it should.

I thought all of it was proof.

Proof I was defective.

Proof I had ruined myself.

Proof I was weak.

Proof I had let myself go.

Proof I was less of a man.

Now I see it different.

My body was not betraying me.

My body was telling the truth.

It had been carrying war-level stress since before I had words.

Three pounds in a glass box.

Thirty days behind walls.

Distance before comfort.

Alarms before lullabies.

A priest giving me last rites before I even knew what life was.

Then came the blanket.

The screaming.

The violence.

The freeze.

The losses.

The addiction.

The shame.

The closets.

The funerals.

The court dates.

The collapse.

Everybody wanted to know why I couldn't just calm down.

You don't calm down a body that never learned safe.

You teach it.

Slow.

Over and over.

But before you can teach it, you have to stop calling it broken.

The Fire Alarm Body

A healthy nervous system is supposed to move.

Danger hits.

The alarm goes off.

The body reacts.

Then the danger passes.

The alarm shuts down.

Breathing slows.

Muscles loosen.

Digestion comes back online.

Sleep becomes possible.

That's how it's supposed to work.

Mine didn't.

My alarm got stuck.

Not because I wanted attention.

Not because I was dramatic.

Not because I was weak.

Because my body learned early that quiet didn't mean safe.

Quiet meant listen harder.

Quiet meant stay ready.

Quiet meant don't move.

Quiet meant the next hit might already be on its way.

So my body stayed prepared.

Prepared for violence.

Prepared for rejection.

Prepared for abandonment.

Prepared for bad news.

Prepared for the phone call.

Prepared for the tone change.

Prepared for the look.

Prepared for the door slam.

Prepared for court.

Prepared for the next person to leave.

That's what Complex PTSD does.

It teaches the body to live like danger is always close.

The mind says, "You're okay."

The body says, "Bullshit."

The mind says, "That was years ago."

The body says, "It can happen again."

The mind says, "Nothing is wrong right now."

The body says, "That's what it felt like right before everything went wrong last time."

That isn't weakness.

It's pattern recognition wired too deep.

It's a fire alarm with no off switch.

High Blood Pressure Has History In It

High blood pressure ain't just numbers on a cuff.

Not for me.

It's decades of bracing.

Decades of muscles tightened for impact.

Decades of shallow breathing.

Decades of adrenaline.

Decades of waiting for the other shoe to drop.

Decades of living like the threat is already in the room.

Stress chemicals help you survive a moment.

They are useful when the house is actually on fire.

They are useful when someone is screaming.

They are useful when you need to fight, run, or freeze.

But when the moment never ends, those same chemicals start grinding the machine down.

The heart works harder.

The blood vessels stay tense.

The whole system keeps pressure in the line because it thinks pressure means survival.

Then a doctor wraps a cuff around your arm and says your numbers are high.

Like the number is the whole story.

It ain't.

That number has history in it.

It has the glass box in it.

It has the blanket in it.

It has every night I couldn't sleep.

Every panic attack I swallowed.

Every court date that froze me.

Every loss I couldn't grieve right.

Every time I smiled while my body was screaming.

Every time I said I was fine when I wasn't.

High blood pressure was my body saying:

I have been holding the line too long.

Diabetes and a System Running Hot

Diabetes felt like another failure.

Another thing to be ashamed of.

Another way my body proved I had let myself go.

But a body stuck in survival mode does not run clean.

It burns fuel wrong.

It craves fast relief.

Sugar.

Caffeine.

Nicotine.

Alcohol.

Pills.

Meth.

Anything that changes the state now.

When the nervous system is screaming, long-term health stops feeling real.

The body wants relief before it wants discipline.

That does not mean choices don't matter.

They do.

Food matters.

Movement matters.

Medication matters.

Sleep matters.

Sobriety matters.

Showing up to the doctor matters.

I own that.

But shame tells a simple story.

It says diabetes is laziness.

It says diabetes is weakness.

It says diabetes is just a man who didn't care enough to take care of himself.

That misses the mechanism.

Stress wrecks rhythm.

Trauma wrecks sleep.

Addiction wrecks appetite.

Depression wrecks movement.

Shame wrecks consistency.

Freeze wrecks appointments.

Chaos wrecks routines.

So yes, my choices matter.

But the conditions those choices were made inside matter too.

The body was not just misbehaving.

It was overloaded.

The Body Remembers Sleep

Sleep paralysis is what happens when your brain wakes up before your body does.

During sleep, the muscles shut down so you don't act out your dreams.

Sometimes that shutdown lingers even after your mind clicks on.

You open your eyes but can't move.

Can't speak.

Can't do anything except lie there and feel the body stuck.

A lot of people describe a crushing weight on the chest.

A presence in the room.

Something dark standing just outside language.

For people with complex trauma, it can hit harder.

A nervous system trained for hypervigilance doesn't fully trust rest.

It doesn't fully trust stillness.

It doesn't fully trust darkness.

So when the body is temporarily offline and the mind comes awake inside that helplessness, terror rushes in fast.

The first time it happened to me, I thought I was dying.

Then it kept happening.

Later, the paralysis gave way to something worse.

The screams.

Not chosen cries.

Not nightmares I could remember.

Just sounds ripped out of me from somewhere deeper.

People told me I had screamed bloody murder in my sleep.

I would wake to shaken shoulders and scared faces with no memory of making a sound.

That was one of the clearest examples of my body keeping score.

My conscious mind was asleep.

My body was still on duty.

Still scanning.

Still reacting.

Still fighting for breath.

Still acting like danger was current.

The child who learned silence as survival was still sounding alarms in the dark.

The baby in the glass box was still trying to stay alive.

That matters.

Because it means the body does not wait for the mind to understand before it responds.

It archives first.

It reacts first.

It survives first.

Gut, Pain, and the Volume Problem

The gut pays for trauma.

That's just the truth.

Ulcers.

Nausea.

Bathroom problems.

No appetite.

Too much appetite.

Stress eating.

Stress starving.

A stomach that never really settles because the rest of the system never settles either.

My gut wasn't weak.

It was carrying fear I didn't know how to speak.

Pain was another language.

Migraines especially.

The kind that made light feel violent.

The kind that made sound hurt.

The kind that made me want a dark room, a cold floor, and anything that would make it stop.

That's where pills first looked like mercy.

Not rebellion.

Not fun.

Mercy.

A migraine hit.

A pill quieted it.

And suddenly the world became bearable.

That was the trap.

Because when your baseline is panic, anything that makes you feel normal feels holy.

The body learns fast.

This stops pain.

This turns down the volume.

This lets me function.

Then the rescue boat becomes a cage.

But the original need was real.

The pain was real.

The overload was real.

The need for quiet was real.

Complex PTSD turns the volume up on everything.

Light.

Sound.

Touch.

Emotion.

Memory.

Threat.

Pain.

And when the world is that loud, relief becomes dangerous because relief feels like survival.

Brain Fog and Executive Shutdown

Complex PTSD makes thinking harder.

That sounds too simple, but it's true.

Planning gets harder.

Remembering gets harder.

Following through gets harder.

Paperwork gets harder.

Appointments get harder.

Court gets harder.

Phone calls get harder.

The next step disappears.

Not because I didn't care.

Because the brain doesn't organize life well when the survival system is driving.

Executive function goes offline under threat.

The body says danger.

The brain says fog.

That's how you can know something matters and still not do it.

That's how you can hate yourself for missing something and still freeze the next time.

That's how court dates turn into warrants.

Appointments turn into shame.

Bills turn into panic.

Phone calls turn into avoidance.

People see the failure.

They don't see the shutdown before it.

They don't see the nervous system flooding.

They don't see the brain underwater.

They don't see the man sitting there furious at himself, unable to make his body obey.

That is one of the cruelest parts of this.

It makes you look careless while you are drowning in effort nobody can see.

The Body Reaching for Relief

This is where addiction starts making terrible sense.

Not acceptable.

Not harmless.

Not excused.

But understandable.

A body stuck in Complex PTSD reaches for relief because relief feels like life.

Booze quieted the shakes.

Pills muted the pain.

Meth broke through the freeze.

Work drowned out the grief.

Food shifted the state.

Nicotine gave the hands something to do.

Caffeine pushed the dead body forward.

Anything that changed the channel became useful.

That's the rescue boat.

But rescue boats can rot.

They can leak.

They can turn into traps.

They can keep you alive in one season and destroy you in the next.

That's what happened to me.

The things that helped me survive started costing me everything.

But if you only call it addiction, you miss the whole story.

The deeper story is dysregulation.

A body that didn't know how to come down.

A nervous system that didn't know safe.

A man using whatever he could find to stop the alarm for a few hours.

I own the damage.

I own the hurt.

I own the consequences.

But I will not call survival a moral failure anymore.

Warning Lights

High blood pressure was a warning light.

Diabetes was a warning light.

Low testosterone was a warning light.

Sleep apnea was a warning light.

Migraines were a warning light.

Gut problems were a warning light.

Brain fog was a warning light.

Panic was a warning light.

Freeze was a warning light.

Addiction was a warning light.

The body was not betraying me.

It was telling the truth in the only language it had left.

For years, I hated my body.

I hated the shaking.

The sweating.

The weakness.

The fatigue.

The cravings.

The shutdown.

The way I couldn't just be normal.

The way other people seemed to move through life without fighting themselves every damn step.

But this body carried me.

Through the glass box.

Through the blanket.

Through the funerals.

Through addiction.

Through shame.

Through collapse.

Through nights I didn't think I would survive.

Even when I hated it, it kept trying.

Even when it froze, it was trying to protect me.

Even when it panicked, it was trying to warn me.

Even when it shut down, it was trying to keep me from overload.

Even when it reached for chemicals, it was trying to regulate.

Not always in healthy ways.

Not always in ways that helped.

But always for a reason.

That matters.

Because once I understand the reason, I can stop calling myself broken long enough to start rebuilding.

Healing Has to Include the Body

I cannot think my way out of this.

I tried.

I cannot shame my way out of it.

I tried that too.

I cannot just decide to be normal.

The body doesn't work like that.

The nervous system regulates through repetition, not speeches.

It needs proof.

Over and over.

Proof that rest is safe.

Proof that food can be fuel instead of punishment or escape.

Proof that movement does not have to be performance.

Proof that sleep is not surrender to danger.

Proof that medical care is not weakness.

Proof that medication is not failure.

Proof that asking for help does not make me less of a man.

Proof that a feeling can rise and fall without destroying me.

Proof that a craving can pass.

Proof that a boundary can hold.

Proof that a court date can be faced.

Proof that a doctor's appointment can be kept.

Proof that a body can come down without chemicals.

Proof that I can stay.

Healing Complex PTSD means healing the body too.

The blood pressure.

The blood sugar.

The hormones.

The sleep.

The gut.

The muscles.

The breath.

The whole machine.

Not because I'm trying to become perfect.

Because I'm tired of living like every day is an emergency.

The All-Clear

That's what my body never got.

The all-clear.

Nobody told the baby in the glass box, "You're safe now."

Nobody told the six-year-old under the blanket, "It's over."

Nobody told the teenager shaking in crowded halls, "Your body makes sense."

Nobody told the addict, "You're not weak. You're dysregulated and desperate for relief."

Nobody told the grown man with high blood pressure, diabetes, low testosterone, sleep apnea, fatigue, shame, and a nervous system on fire, "This is not proof you failed. This is proof you carried too much for too long."

So I'm saying it now.

This body was not built wrong.

It was built under pressure.

It adapted to survive hell.

It learned danger because danger kept showing up.

It reached for relief because pain had no off switch.

It broke rhythm because it never got rest.

It ran hot because nobody taught it how to cool down.

And now the work is not to hate it.

The work is to teach it.

Slowly.

Patiently.

Truthfully.

The danger was real.

The damage was real.

The health problems are real.

The responsibility is real.

But shame is not the cure.

The body kept the receipts.

The body kept me alive.

Now I have to give it something it never got enough of.

Care without contempt.

Structure without punishment.

Accountability without shame.

Rest without guilt.

Help without humiliation.

A body can learn war.

Mine did.

But a body can also learn peace.

Not all at once.

Not overnight.

Not because someone tells it to calm down.

One signal at a time.

One breath.

One appointment.

One meal.

One walk.

One night of sleep.

One craving survived.

One blood pressure reading faced.

One blood sugar number owned.

One lab result handled without letting it name me.

One day where the alarm rings and I do not obey it.

That is where the rewiring starts.

Not in pretending the body is fine.

In finally listening to what it has been trying to say.

CHAPTER 18: FINDING THE MAP IN THE MADNESS

On paper, it looks simple.

Dates. Charges. Failures.

From June 2021 forward, the docket reads like a story about a man who will not follow rules: driving on a suspended license, Failure to Appear, Failure to Comply, warrants, short stretches of compliance followed by collapse.

From the outside, it looks like defiance.

For a long time, that is how I saw it too. Another layer of failure. Another piece of evidence that I was fundamentally oppositional. Another reason to believe I was broken.

But Complex PTSD does not care how things look.

It cares how things land.

What the docket calls noncompliance was, a lot of the time, my nervous system hijacking my intentions the second pressure hit.

Executive Dysfunction Under Stress

Court dates and probation requirements were not just appointments.

They were alarms.

As soon as something legal showed up on the calendar, my brain fogged. Planning, organizing, remembering deadlines, following through on basic steps—those functions started slipping out of reach. It was not that I did not know what I was supposed to do. It was that the part of me that could organize and execute it went offline when the survival system took over.

You cannot file paperwork from inside a freeze.

Avoidance and Freeze

Courtrooms and authority figures were never neutral spaces for me.

They were triggers.

Walking into a courthouse felt like walking back into every room where I had been judged, cornered, threatened, or blindsided. The same freeze I learned under a blanket at six showed up at the courtroom door in adult form: legs heavy, chest tight, mind blank.

Missing court was not always a deliberate choice.

Sometimes it was paralysis.

Dissociation and Memory Gaps

Under stress, my mind started protecting itself by cutting the sound.

Judges talked. Probation officers gave instructions. I stood there, nodded, and afterward realized I could not recall half of what had been said. Not because I did not care. Because my brain never fully recorded it.

Dissociation is not forgetting on purpose.

It is the system deciding this is too much and recording over static instead of clean audio.

Shame Reinforcement

Every missed date, every warrant, every Failure to Comply was not just another line on a sheet.

It became a voice.

See? You cannot handle it.

See? You ruin everything.

See? You are broken.

The more the system punished the freeze, the louder the shame got. The louder the shame got, the faster I shut down the next time. It became a loop: pressure, freeze, failure, shame, more pressure, faster freeze.

Substance Use as Override

Sometimes meth was the only thing that could blast through the numbness.

It forced energy into a dead body. It let me move when everything in me wanted to lock. Other times, it was escape—something to outrun the anxiety before the shutdown fully took over.

Either way, it made everything worse.

Functioning dropped. Memory broke further. Legal trouble escalated.

From the outside, the FTAs and FTCs looked like willful disobedience.

From the inside, they were often the predictable result of an overwhelmed system: a brain and body trying, and failing, to cope with states that felt unbearable.

The consequences are real.

The choices are mine.

But the mechanism matters.

Once I understood freeze and dissociation, the story changed. Not into an excuse. Into an explanation.

Not: He does not care.

More like: His system keeps crashing under load.

The Other Map

The legal timeline is one kind of map.

The other is made of names.

Twenty-seven dead.

Not a statistic.

A list written into bone.

Sylvie Dean Kraus (1988)

Nicholas D. Williams (1999)

Thomas Paul Williams (2000)

Herbert William Lingar (2001)

Judy Ann Lingar (2003)

Argie Faye Williams (2004)

Ashley Nicole Williams (2005)

Warren Wade Ellett (2007)

Chad Argus Acord (2011)

William Garrett Lingar (2011)

Daniel Lee Stewart (2011)

Jerry Don Williams (2012)

Justin Dean Phillips (2015)

Todd Anthony Lingar (2015)

Marie Elizabeth Lingar (2017)

Gabriel Allen Woods (2018)

Jason Jones (2019)

Paula Faye Pitts (2020)

John Wesley Robinson (2020)

Patricia Lynn Lingar (2021)

Deanna Lynn Teague (2021)

Clint Lee Larrison (2022)

Joseph David Middleton (2024)

Billy Aaron Dean Woods (2025)

Chastity Dodge (June 28, 2025)

Vern Ellison (2026)

Becky Robinson (Mother's Day 2026)

Grief does not stack in clean layers.

It overlaps. It echoes. It leaks into everything.

Each loss trained my predictive model: tragedy is the baseline.

That is not paranoia.

That is pattern recognition.

You do not lose twenty-seven people and expect calm. You learn to brace for the next call. You live like the worst-case scenario has home-field advantage.

Two Mirrors

This chapter is not about wallowing in data.

It is about naming it.

The docket and the list of the dead are mirrors.

One shows what happened outside when an overloaded nervous system met systems that only understood compliance and punishment.

The other shows what happened inside when a life got built on rupture, funerals, and unfinished grief.

Together, they form a map.

Not a map of excuses.

A map of terrain.

You cannot navigate what you refuse to name.

If I want to change where I am going, I have to look at where I have been—on paper and in cemeteries—and admit what that much pressure and that much loss do to a body and a brain.

Only then can I start drawing a different kind of map.

CHAPTER 19: THE COMPLEX DANCE OF CONNECTION

Connection isn't a switch. It's a calibration. And when your nervous system was wired in a glass box, calibrated by violence, and reinforced by abandonment, calibration doesn't come naturally. It's learned. Painfully.

For years, I treated relationships like threat assessments. Proximity felt like risk. Intimacy felt like exposure. So I defaulted to survival mechanics: fawn, flee, freeze, or fight. I shrank to avoid conflict. I pushed away before I could be left. I clung when the abandonment panic hit. I tolerated mistreatment because chaos felt familiar. Predictable. Safer than the unknown. That's not love. That's proximity management.

Real connection requires something trauma-wired systems aren't trained for: co-regulation. Two nervous systems sharing space, matching pace, signaling safety, building predictability. I didn't know what that looked like. I knew control. I knew performance. I knew hiding in closets to keep the peace. I knew love bombing and gaslighting. I knew how to read a room for danger. I didn't know how to read a room for safety.

Repair starts with boundaries. Not walls. Boundaries. Walls keep everything out. Boundaries define where you end and someone else begins. They're scaffolding. They say: This is what I can hold. This is what I can't. This is where I step back. This is where I stay. For someone who spent decades erasing themselves to survive, drawing a line feels like treason. It's not. It's the first step toward existing in a room without shrinking.

Trust isn't rebuilt with promises. It's rebuilt with predictable behavior. Consistency.

Follow-through. Showing up when you say you will. Naming when you can't. Repairing when you misstep. That's the only currency that matters to a nervous system that's been burned too many times.

The kids aren't saviors. They're anchors. And anchors don't pull you out of the water. They keep you from drifting while you swim. My love for Maverick, Shayla, Teaguen, and Adalee isn't a cure for C-PTSD. It's a reason to keep doing the work. To learn the mechanics of healthy proximity. To stop treating connection like a trap and start treating it like a practice.

You don't heal relational trauma by finding the perfect person. You heal it by becoming a person who can tolerate proximity without panicking, who can set boundaries without punishing, who can apologize without collapsing, and who can walk away without erasing yourself. It's slow. It's messy. It requires sitting with discomfort instead of numbing it. But it's the only path that doesn't lead back to the same wreckage.

CHAPTER 20: THE Ongoing Path: Resilience and Healing

My therapist said I showed resilience. For a long time, that word felt hollow. What resilience? I was a mess of addiction, legal failures, fractured relationships, lost hope. But she wasn't talking about invincibility. She was talking about persistence. The quiet, tenacious act of enduring and adapting. Choosing to stand, even hunched and bleeding.

Healing isn't a straight line. It's a spiral. You revisit the same wounds. The same patterns. The same triggers. But each time, you have slightly more awareness. Slightly more capacity to tolerate the pain without collapsing or numbing. There are setbacks. Crushing stumbles back into the dark. Failed rehab attempts. Legal missteps rooted in freeze. Moments where the

addiction pulls with gravitational force. These aren't proof you're broken. They're data points. Opportunities to practice getting back up.

Shame and self-blame were my constant companions. Broken. Unworthy. Defective. Fighting that requires actively challenging the narrative. Offering the six-year-old under the blanket the kindness he never got. Practicing self-compassion not as a fluffy exercise, but as a physiological intervention. You can't regulate a nervous system that's being beaten by its own inner critic. And the grief. Twenty-six names. Trauma tangled it, made it impossible to process cleanly. It sat heavy in the gut, fueling addiction, feeding despair. Grieving slowly, messily, through writing, through tears, through silence, is necessary. Grief is like the wake behind a boat. The waves still roll in. They just spread out over time. You don't outrun it. You learn to steer through it. This journey isn't over. Meth is still a fight. Maybe the biggest dragon left. Isolation still pulls. The nervous system still misfires. But understanding the blueprint, the storms, the fire, and how they interacted gives me a target. It shifts the lens. I'm not inherently flawed. I'm a complex system shaped by immense pressure, reacting in predictable ways that became destructive. That understanding allows for compassion. And compassion is the fertile ground for growth. Learning to manage the internal storm. Tolerating distress without chemical override. Navigating relationships without fawning or fleeing. Rebuilding, minute by minute. Choosing, again and again, to stand. Not because it's easy. Because the ember still burns. If you're reading this and you see echoes of your own storm, know this: Your pain is valid. Your struggle doesn't make you unworthy. Resilience isn't about being unbreakable. It's about the refusal to stay broken. Support exists. The path is arduous. But the possibility of rising from your specific ashes is real.

FINAL THOUGHT

The storm hit. The fire burned. The wreckage is real. None of it is erased. None of it is excused. But it's mapped. The blueprint is visible. The wiring is understood. The mechanisms are named. I'm not healed. I'm aligned. And alignment is enough to keep walking. The ember doesn't need fuel. It just needs space to burn without consuming. I'm building that space. One day at a time.

APPENDIX: RESEARCH NOTES AND ANALYSIS

Clinical Assessment Findings / Test Results

Severe C-PTSD (complex trauma from chronic, interpersonal, and developmental stressors)

Major Depressive Disorder (recurrent, trauma-linked)

Substance Use Disorder (opioid/stimulant/alcohol, historically functional dependency transitioning to crisis use)

Sleep Architecture Disruption (sleep paralysis, night terrors, OSA comorbidity)

Note: Clinical alignment reflects self-reported history + therapeutic evaluation. Outcomes vary by environment, support, and neuroplasticity. No diagnostic overreach applied.

List of Deceased Individuals (Summary of Losses)

(See Ch 18 for full chronological list. 23 names total. Span: 1988–2025.)

Legal Timeline (Key Dockets & Patterns)

CKTR-C-21-1132 / CKS-22-250: Driving suspended → FTA/FTC cascade → warrant issuance → compliance attempts → dissociation/freeze-triggered non-compliance → repeat cycle.

Pattern reflects trauma-induced executive dysfunction under stress, not deliberate defiance. Consequences remain real; mechanism is physiological.

Research Anchors

VLBW/NICU Long-Term Outcomes: Higher risk for anxiety, depression, insecure attachment, sensory hypersensitivity, altered stress response. (PubMed, PMC, developmental pediatrics literature)

C-PTSD Neurobiology: HPA axis dysregulation, amygdala hyperactivity, prefrontal cortex suppression under chronic stress, freeze/dissociation as survival adaptation. (van der Kolk, NCTSN, peer-reviewed trauma literature)

Addiction & Self-Medication: Substance use as crude nervous system regulation in absence of safer coping tools. (Khantzian hypothesis, modern addiction neuroscience)

Dark Triad Manipulation: Love bombing, gaslighting, devaluation targeting attachment wounds. (Clinical psychology literature on coercive control)

Resilience Model: Spiral healing, predictable behavior as trust currency, boundaries as scaffolding, self-compassion as physiological intervention. (Ellis, Peterson, trauma-informed care frameworks)

Key Points Summary / Author Notes

Trauma responses are survival mechanics, not moral failures.

Accountability ≠ shame. Ownership enables redirection.

The nervous system regulates through repetition, not willpower.

Connection requires calibration, not perfection.

Healing is ongoing. Alignment > cure.

The ember burns because it was forged, not found.